

सार्वजनिक सूचना सर्वेक्षणकार को सूचित किया जाता है कि यहाँ निर्वाचित नये जमाने खुलने के कारण मोरमन्द व नामी गाम धर्पणनी दुम्ने जमान निवासि RZ-3203, Gall No. 36, Tughlakabad Extn., New Delhi-110019 ने अपने पूरे अनुग्रह उर्फ साहित्य को उसके परिवारधन में गत अगस्त के काराज अनुसार अपनी संपत्ति पर उत्तरावली करने के लिये शरीफ कर उसको सारी स्याबियाँ देकर खाली कर लिए हैं। इन्हीं दिषयमें मैं इस से कोई भी व्यक्ति किसी प्रकार का संबंध अधिका तवे देना कता है तो वह स्वयं के विषयम पर होगा। इसमें मेरे मुखबिरका एवं उसके बिचार को किसी प्रकार से कोई हानिमंदी नहीं होगी। हरप्रति (इच्छुकोंके) चैबर नुं ८७४ साकेत कोर्ट नई दिल्ली।	PUBLIC NOTICE My clients Udhram Singh S/o Attar Singh Madhu W/o Udhram Singh Bhatia RZ-3888, 3rd Floor C-Block, Gopal Mandir Marg, Dabri Extn, Delhi-45 have severed all their relations & debarred their son Siddharth Shalani from their all movable - immovable properties due to his antisocial acts. My client shall not be responsible in future. Yogesh Kumar (Advocate) Ch. No. 627 Rohini Court Delhi.
IN CASE OF ANY QUERIES, WRITE TO US AT - AXIS BANK LTD., AXIS HOUSE, TOWER 12, AND FLOOR, 1-14, SECTOR-128, NOIDA EXPRESSWAY, JAYPREE GREENS WISHTOWN, NOIDA (U.P.)-201301.	
REGISTERED OFFICE : "TRISHUL" – 3RD FLOOR OPP. SAMARTHESWAR TEMPLE, NEAR LAW GARDEN, ELLISBRIDGE, AHMEDABAD-380006. TELEPHONE NO. 279-26409322 FAX NO. 279-26409322. E-MAIL ID: 11063192@PIB.VI WEBSITE - WWW.AXISBANK.COM	
APPEAL IN DEFENCE FOR THE POSSESSION OF THE PROPERTY (FOR IMMEDIATE REPLY)	
Whereas the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 3 of the said Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued demand notice dated 29-Jul-2025 calling Mr. SANJAY KUMAR TRIPATHI to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs. 20,93,721/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh Ninety Three Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty One Only) as on 29-Jul-2025 and interest and cost thereon within sixty days from the date of receipt of the said notice.	
The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s) and the Public in General that the undersigned has taken possession of the Property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 on 30-04-2026	
The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/ Mortgagor(s)/ Guarantor(s) above said in particular and the Public in General is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount of Rs. 20,93,721/- (Rupees Twenty Lakh Ninety Three Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty One Only) as on 29-Jul-2025 together with full interest thereat at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment + expenses thereon.	
The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s)/Mortgagor(s)/Guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured	
DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY ALL THAT PART AND PARCEL OF PROPERTY BEARING: Flat Bearing No-K-902 (9th Floor), Situated In Vrinda City , Constructed On Plot No. GH-02 Of Sector 13 Block-C With Great Noida District Gautam Budh Nagar, UP-201308 And Bounded As Under:- East :- As Per Site Plan, West :- As Per Site Plan, North :- As Per Site Plan, South :- As Per Side Plan	
The Borrower(s)/Co-Borrower(s) or sub section 13 of section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without priorwritten consent of our bank.	
Dated: 03-05-2026, Place: GREATER NOIDA Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.	

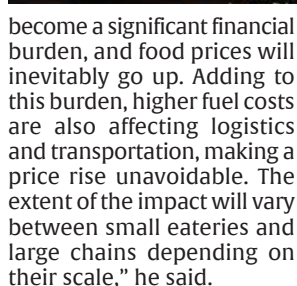
PUBLIC NOTICE Mr. Pankit Goyal has approached ICICI Bank Ltd., Gurgaon, Sector-63, Farjana. (Bank) to avail a loan for purchase of Property No. 166, (240 sq. ft.), Block-C, Sector-44, Noida, Distt. Gautam Budh Nagar. U.P. from M/S KDR Infrastructure Pvt. Ltd., who has represented that it is the absolute owner of the said property by way of Transfer deed dated 29.09.2023 (Doc. No. 8787) executed by Mr. Murme Wangdi Vangchuk. If anybody, person, body corporate has any right, lien or claim whatsoever on the said Property by way of inheritance, mortgage, sale or otherwise, then he/she/it may contact me undnsigned with documentary proof of claim within 15 days of publication of this notice, otherwise it shall be deemed that either there are no claims or the same have been waived off. No claim or objection shall be entertained thereafter and Bank shall proceed to advance the loan on mortgaging of the said property. Amit Kumar, Advocate GNA & Associates -28, Jungpura Extension, New Delhi-110014.	The Pioneer Classified ♦ CHANGE OF NAME ♦ I, RAKESH, S/O SHRI RAM CHANDRA R/O K-1887, JAHAANGIRPURI DELHI 110033. HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO RAKESH KUMAR, (RAKESH AND RAKESH KUMAR IS SAME PERSON) PD(101)C I, BIRAMMO, W/O, BALWANT SINGH, R/O, K-1679, JAHAANGIRPURI, DELHI-110033. HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO BIRMO DEVI (BIRAMMO AND BIRMO DEVI IS THE SAME PERSON) PD(101)C
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PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Manpreet Singh, honorary treasurer of the National Restaurant Association of India, said that eateries are

Singh further said that as costs mount, smaller establishments could struggle to stay afloat. Instead, the association has advised restaur-

"If this continues, it will



A West Delhi-based restaurateur said they are trying to manage rising costs while keeping their staff secure.

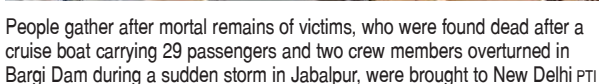
"We are checking our costs very carefully and trying to cut wherever possible, but if fuel prices remain high, it will

"Whenever cylinders were unavailable, I had to buy them at higher rates in the black market. Now even regular supply is too expen-

On April 1, the rates of commercial LPG cylinders were hiked by ₹195.50 per cylinder, followed by a ₹114.5 hike on March 1, taking the total increase over the past three months to ₹1,303. With the latest revision, a 19 kg commercial LPG cylinder now costs ₹3,371.5 in Delhi, up from ₹2,078.5 earlier.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Three from the family — Marina, 39, her four-year-old son Trishan, also called



They were to return to Berlin on Thursday and reach it by Friday. Instead, they went sightseeing, and then this

suddenly everything changed. She kept crying, 'Save me... save me...' and after that the phone disconnected," he said. He further

However, by the time he turned to search for the rest of the family, they had disappeared, trapped beneath the overturned vessel. Mohan

"It was hardly 150 to 200 metres from the shore, but the waves were so strong that people kept getting pushed back. If it is a tourist place, there should be a permanent rescue team. Emergencies do not come with warning," he said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

The chief minister attended a tourism stakeholders conference as the chief guest, where a wide range of issues

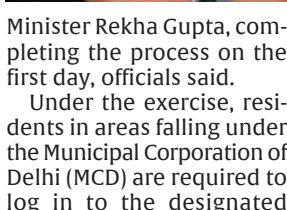


from tourism and hospitality to heritage, spiritual, digital, medical and wellness tourism, as well as night tourism and Delhi's branding positioning, were discussed in detail. Addressing the gathering, the chief minister said Delhi, as the national capital, has unique features. "We are trying to positively rebrand Delhi in the tourism sector so that tourists see this city as a destination and enjoy its unique features, not just as a transit point," she said.

The conference was attended by Delhi's Minister for Art, Culture and Tourism Kapil Mishra, Managing Director of the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTDC) Suneel Anchipaka and several experts from the tourism and allied sectors.

The chief minister said the active participation of industry stakeholders, policymakers and domain experts had led to several concrete and actionable suggestions.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi



Under the exercise, residents in areas falling under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) are required to log in to the designated

At the same time, authorities have warned of fraud-

Residents have been advised to report any such incidents to the Cyber Crime Helpline at 1930 immediately.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

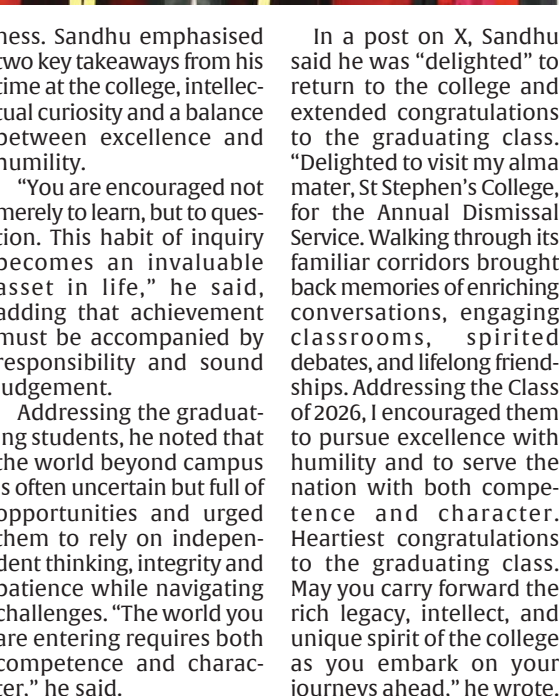
The police analysed CCTV footage from the nearby area and identified a female suspect. "During the inquiry, it emerged that the suspect was working as a home tutor at the house. Further verification revealed that she lived in Paschim Puri," a senior police officer said. Acting on the lead, the police conducted a raid at her residence and apprehended her.

Addressing the graduating students, he noted that the world beyond campus is often uncertain but full of opportunities and urged them to rely on independent thinking, integrity and patience while navigating challenges. "The world you are entering requires both competence and character," he said.

In a post on X, Sandhu told he was “delighted” to turn to the college and extended congratulations to the graduating class. Delighted to visit my alma mater, St Stephen's College, for the Annual Dismissal Service. Walking through familiar corridors brought back memories of enriching conversations, engaging classrooms, spirited debates, and lifelong friendships. Addressing the Class of 2026, I encouraged them to pursue excellence with humility and to serve the nation with both competence and character. My earliest congratulations to the graduating class. May you carry forward the rich legacy, intellect, and unique spirit of the college as you embark on your journey ahead.” he wrote.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Recalling his student days, the LG said memories of classrooms, debates and conversations continue to influence his life and career. Highlighting the college's legacy, he said the institution has, for over a century, nurtured generations who have contributed across fields, including public service, academia and busi-





OUR CENSUS OUR DEVELOPMENT



गृह मंत्रालय
भारत
सरकार

(First Phase of Census 2027)

Common queries on Self-Enumeration (SE) and their Answers (Part-1)

WHAT IS SELF-ENUMERATION?

Self-Enumeration is an online process in which you fill and submit your household details on the SE portal (se.census.gov.in) yourself, without waiting for an enumerator



- ❖ **Is Self-Enumeration mandatory?**
No, it is an additional facility. If you do not do it, an enumerator will collect data during field visit
- ❖ **Can I do Self-Enumeration in any language?**
This facility is available in Hindi, English and 14 Indian languages
- ❖ **Is internet required for Self-Enumeration?**
Yes, internet is required to access the portal
- ❖ **Is my information safe?**
Yes, all data is secure, encrypted and stored on government servers
- ❖ **What is SE ID and its use?**
After submission of information, you will receive a unique 11 digit SE ID (Also via SMS/email) which must be shown to the enumerator during her/his visit to your house
- ❖ **What if SE ID is forgotten?**
It can be retrieved using the registered mobile number on the portal
- ❖ **Will an enumerator visit after Self-Enumeration?**
Yes, the enumerator will visit your home and confirm your details using the SE ID
- ❖ **Do I need to upload any documents?**
No documents are required to be uploaded
- ❖ **Is help available on the portal?**
Portal has user guide, flowcharts, tutorial videos, FAQs and tooltips



TOLL FREE - 1855

Let us fulfill our responsibility, Let us participate in the Census






CensusIndia2027

IN FOCUS



An adult rose-ringed parakeet feeds its chicks in a tree hole in Guwahati, Assam, on Saturday

PTI

PM to inaugurate ₹150 crore Sardardham Complex in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vadodara

Sardardham is set to inaugurate a major educational and residential complex in Vadodara on May 11 marking a significant step toward its vision of nation-building through community development inspired by Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel.

The newly constructed “Dr Dushyant and Daksha Patel Complex,” located near Waghodia Crossroads along National Highway-48 beside L&T Knowledge City, will be inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at 4.30 pm.

Built at an estimated cost of ₹150 crore, the sprawling facility covers around 4,75,000 square



feet and is designed to accommodate 2,000 students from the Patidar community.

It includes separate hostel-cum-institute arrangements for 1,000 boys and 1,000 girls.

The complex features

278 rooms, a 400-seat e-library, a 1,000-capacity auditorium, and specialised training centres for competitive exams such as GPSC and UPSC, as well as defence and judicial services.

Additional amenities

include an NRI service centre, student counselling facilities, and yoga and meditation spaces.

The event is expected to see the presence of several prominent leaders, including Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, Union Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, and other senior political and social figures.

The project has been made possible through contributions from several donors within the Patidar community, with key support from industrialists and philanthropists. Sardardham leaders, under the guidance of Gagjibhai Sutariya, have been actively coordinating efforts to ensure the successful execution of the project.

MeT issues alert for thunderstorm, hail, gusty winds in Himachal



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Shimla

Light showers took place in isolated areas of Himachal Pradesh over the past 24 hours, with Saharan recording maximum precipitation with 18.5 mm rainfall, while Shimla and Manali also saw traces of rain. The meteorological station(MeT) has issued a warning for thunderstorm accompanied by lightning, hail and gusty winds at 40-50 kmph, at isolated places in Kullu, Mandi, Solan Shimla and Sirmaur on May 4.

It also issued an alert for thunderstorm and gusty winds at 30-40 kmph at isolated places in all ten non-tribal districts on May 3 and 5 and in Una, Bilaspur, Hamirpur, Chamba and Kangra on May 4.

The MeT station has forecast the wet spell to last till May 8, with light to moderate rains at

most places between May 3 and 5.

Most places across the state saw some rainfall on Saturday, with Dharamshala logging 6.3 mm rainfall, while Mandi received 5 mm, Sangla 2.4 mm, and Seobagh 2.2 mm.

The state received 161.2 mm average rainfall during the pre-monsoon season from March 1 to May 2 this year against a normal of 183.3 mm, a deficit of around 12 per cent.

Barring Kinnaur, Lahaul and Spiti and Chamba which saw 43 per cent, 42 per cent and 12 per cent rain deficit, respectively, the remaining nine districts received excess rain ranging between 98 per cent (Solan) and 1 per cent (Kullu). Bilaspur received 83 per cent excess rain, followed by Mandi, Shimla and Sirmaur at 50 per cent, Una at 43 per cent, Hamirpur at 41 per cent and Kangra at 9 per cent.

Gujarat HC upholds acquittal in two 2002 riot cases, cites lack of proof

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The Gujarat High Court has upheld the acquittal of accused individuals in two separate cases linked to the 2002 communal riots, refusing to interfere with the decisions of the lower courts due

to insufficient evidence.

The court dismissed appeals filed by the state government in 2003 and by a private complainant in 2007.

In one case from Vadodara, the bench upheld a 2003 sessions court ruling that acquitted five individuals accused of burning a man, Samsuddin



alias Kasam Khan, alive during the violence.

According to the prosecution, a mob of nearly 200 people had attacked the victim's house in February 2002 and set him on fire. However, the High Court observed that forensic reports failed to conclusively establish

that the recovered remains belonged to the victim. Additionally, the primary complainant admitted being unable to identify the attackers due to darkness at the time of the incident.

In another case from Panchmahal district, Justice HD Suthar dismissed revision

plea related to the alleged murder of a couple in Rameshwara village in March 2002. The court agreed with trial court's findings, noting significant contradictions in witness statements, lack of identification of weapons, and absence of any accused being apprehended at scene.

FROM PAGE - 1

EC orders fresh poll on Falta Assembly seat

Polling was otherwise peaceful across 15 booths, he said. The Commission said that every person standing in the queue before the close of polling hours would be permitted to vote.

Magrahat Paschim registered 86.11 per cent voter turnout, while in Diamond Harbour, the figure was 87.60 per cent, the official said.

Voting in these two assembly constituencies was held in the second phase of the assembly elections on April 29.

The repoll order was based on reports received from returning officers and observers of the two constituencies and “material circumstances”, he said. In Magrahat Paschim, TMC's Md Samim Ahamed Molla is pitted against BJP nominee Goursundar Ghosh, while Abdul Majid Halder of the Congress and ISF candidate Abdul Aziz Al Hassan are also in the fray.

TMC candidate Panna Lal Halder is contesting against Dipak Kumar Halder of the BJP in the Diamond Harbour seat. Goutam Bhattacharya of the Congress and CPI(M)'s Samar Naiya are among other candidates.

The BJP had alleged rampant electoral malpractices in certain polling stations of both the Assembly seats under the Diamond Harbour Lok Sabha constituency, which is represented by TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee.

The EC had deputised its special observer, Subrata Gupta, to fact-check the allegations from the ground.

The poll panel will decide on repolling in the Falta assembly constituency on Saturday.

The West Bengal assembly elections were held in two phases - April 23 and April 29 - amid unprecedented security arrangements.

Counting of votes will take place on May 4.

CBI extradites Kamlesh Parekh from UAE

Parekh was on the run ever since the case surfaced around 2016-17. An open-ended non-bailable warrant was issued against him in 2019, and he was declared a ‘Fugitive Economic Offender’. A Red Corner Notice was issued through Interpol, prompting sustained diplomatic and law-enforcement efforts between India and the UAE. Following due legal process, the UAE authorities granted extradition. Parekh arrived in Delhi on May 1 and was immediately taken into custody by the CBI's Bank Securities and Fraud Branch (BSFB), Kolkata.

The development is seen as a strong message against economic offenders who flee abroad to evade justice. CBI officials said the agency remains committed to tracing and repatriating more fugitives involved in financial crimes. Parekh's return is expected to strengthen the ongoing probe and aid recovery efforts for the defrauded banks.

ED attaches ₹81,422 cr assets in FY26

The number of searches conducted under PMLA surged to 2,892 in FY-26, almost double the 1,491 raids in the previous year. The agency noted it was moving beyond physical raids by “triangulating financial intelligence from multiple databases,” using blockchain analytics for crypto flows, and accessing real-time corporate and property records.

A record 812 chargesheets were filed in FY-26, as compared to 457 in FY-25. This contributed to slashing the average case lifecycle from 3-4 years to 1-1.5 years, the report States.

According to the data, Enforcement Case Information Reports (ECIRs), the trigger for PMLA probes rose 39 per cent to 1,080 cases from 775 in FY25. The ED restored assets worth ₹32,678 crore to victims of fraud (including investors, homebuyers, and banks), more than double its own target of ₹15,000 crore set by Director Rahul Navin at the start of FY-26. This compares with ₹15,263 crore restituted in FY-25. Nearly half of the FY-26 restitution (₹15,582

crore) came from a single major success in the PACI. Ponzi scheme case.

The Enforcement Directorate derives its formidable authority from the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002. The law empowers the agency to define “proceeds of crime” broadly, conduct searches and seizures, arrest accused persons, and attach properties. Bail remains extremely difficult to secure since courts must be satisfied that the accused is not guilty and is unlikely to commit any offence while on bail. These provisions have enabled the ED to focus on depriving economic offenders of their ill-got gains rather than relying solely on custodial interrogation.

The Annual Report signals a maturing enforcement strategy. By leveraging technology and multi-source intelligence, the ED is filing stronger cases faster, reducing dependence on prolonged physical raids while maintaining high visibility through increased search operations. The focus on asset attachment and restitution aligns with the PMLA's core objective of victim compensation and deterrence.

The agency has claimed that on the international front, cooperation has grown considerably. As of March 31, 2026, the ED had 353 pending Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty (MLAT) and Letters Rogatory (LR) requests, with the highest numbers directed to the UAE (69), Singapore (55), UK (39), Hong Kong (36), USA (26), Switzerland (23) and Mauritius (15). The ED received 246 such requests from foreign jurisdictions, led by the UK (79), Singapore (33) and 32 from the USA.

While the drop in arrests may invite scrutiny from critics who view it as a softening of enforcement, the agency's data presents it as a sign of efficiency: fewer but stronger cases, quicker prosecutions, and record recovery of proceeds of crime for the benefit of victims and the exchequer.

With the ED marking significant milestones, including its 70th year of establishment in 2026, the annual report positions the ED as a bulwark in India's fight against economic offences, terror financing and crypto-related frauds. The record restitution, especially in high-profile Ponzi schemes, is likely to boost public confidence in the system's ability to deliver justice to ordinary investors and stakeholders.

The full annual report is available on the official ED website (enforcementdirectorate.gov.in). As the agency continues to refine its methods amid evolving challenges like digital currencies and cross-border laundering.

Govt's new disaster warning system takes...

Through this system, critical information related to disasters, emergencies, and public safety will be transmitted directly and instantly to citizens' mobile phones, the statement said.

The system is based on the Common Alerting Protocol (CAP) as recommended by the UN body International Telecommunication Union. Designed to deliver critical information instantly during disasters or public safety emergencies, the system works without requiring internet access or mobile apps.

The new Cell Broadcast Solution (CBS) technology represents a significant upgrade over traditional SMS alerts. Unlike regular SMS notifications, Cell Broadcast alerts are designed to grab immediate attention. CBS offers precise geo-targeting capabilities, enabling alerts to be disseminated at the level of individual cell towers or clusters, while also allowing scalability to cover larger geographic areas.

The system enables real-time, multilingual alerts that provide critical time for protective action in disasters such as flash floods and gas leaks. Supported across 2G to 5G networks, it ensures wide reach in both urban and rural areas, including last-mile and roaming populations. By enabling direct, official communication, it strengthens disaster management, drives quick response, reduces panic, and enhances public trust and compliance.

Additionally, alerts are delivered as priority notifications, appearing as pop-up messages accompanied by distinct loud tones, with message text

read aloud on supported mobile handsets. The Government informed that the NDMA has successfully operationalised the Integrated Alert System (SACHET), developed by the Centre for Development of Telematics (C-DOT). It is based on the Common Alerting Protocol (CAP), as recommended by the International Telecommunication Union. Integrated with the CAP-based SACHET platform, it allows rapid and standardised dissemination of alerts. It overcomes the limitations of traditional SMS-based systems, ensuring that critical information can be disseminated quickly and efficiently to large populations within targeted areas.

When triggered, they override normal phone settings, producing a sharp alarm sound along with a prominent on-screen message, ensuring that even users with their devices on silent or do-not-disturb modes are notified. The centre informed that it is currently operational across all 36 States and union Territories, delivering disaster and emergency-related alerts via SMS to mobile users within geo-targeted areas. It has been extensively utilised by disaster management authorities, enabling the dissemination of over 134 billion message alerts to date, in more than 19 languages during natural disasters, weather warnings, and cyclonic events.

EC deploys additional counting observers

Additional counting observers have been appointed to assist the Counting Observers for 165 Assembly Constituencies which have more than one Counting Hall.

According to the poll body, police observers will oversee the security and law and order arrangements around the Counting Centres of the ACs assigned to them and ensure that the security arrangements around the Counting Centres are as per the Commission's instructions. However, the police observers shall not enter the Counting Hall on the day of counting of votes under any circumstance. The Police Observers will function in close coordination with the Counting Observers and other election machinery deployed for the counting process.

In another key directive, the commission barred all individuals except the counting observer and returning officer from carrying mobile phones inside counting halls. To ensure transparency, Form 17C-II recording results from control units will be prepared in the presence of counting agents and shared with them for signatures.

“Micro-Observers deployed at each table will also independently note down the result from the CU display and handover to the Counting Observer at the end of each round for cross-verification,” the poll body said.

The poll body has deploy nearly 2.4 lakh Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) personnel in West Bengal, marking the highest-ever deployment in a single State during elections. After the completion of polling on April 29, 2026, around 200 CAPF companies will remain stationed in the state to guard Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs), strong rooms, and counting centres until the counting process is completed. In addition, 500 CAPF companies will continue to be deployed for law and order duties until further orders. The two-phase polling for the 294 Assembly seats in Bengal took place on April 23 and April 29. The results will be declared on May 4.

Judge dies by suicide in Delhi's Safdarjung area

A police team reached the spot after receiving information about the incident and initiated inquest proceedings. The body has been sent for postmortem, officials said, adding that further investigation is underway. Police suspect it to be a case of suicide.

“No foul play has been established so far. However, all angles are being examined as part of the inquest proceedings,” a senior police officer said.

According to official records, Sharma had joined the Delhi Judicial Services on 19 June 2021.

A law graduate from Symbiosis Law School, Pune, he completed his BA LLB in 2018.

During his tenure, he dealt with a range of criminal and civil cases and served in different jurisdictions as a Judicial Magistrate First Class (JMFC) and civil judge.

With effect from 18 October 2025, Sharma had taken charge as the full-time secretary of the District Legal Services Authority (DLSA) in the North-East district at Karkardooma Courts. He is survived by two children — one of whom is less than nine months old — and his wife, who is also a judge. Police said statements of concerned persons are being recorded, and relevant circumstances leading to the incident are being examined. Last month, a 26-year-old advocate practising at the Delhi High Court allegedly jumped to his death from the 15th-floor balcony of a hotel in New Delhi's Connaught Place on Sunday evening. Police said the deceased, a resident of Mahavir Enclave, also left behind a two-page suicide note in which he held nobody responsible for his death.

CBI brings back passport forgery racket key...

According to CBI officials, he was the mastermind in a sophisticated racket that helped individuals with criminal backgrounds secure Indian passports using fabricated identities, false addresses and counterfeit documents. The network allegedly facilitated the illegal immigration and evasion of justice for several wanted criminals, thus enabling them to travel abroad and potentially continue with their nefarious activities.

The aggressive pursuit began when Haryana Police approached the CBI to issue a Red Notice through Interpol channels. The notice was promptly published, allowing UAE authorities to geo-locate and arrest Kumar. Following a formal extradition request and due legal processes, the UAE handed him over to Indian officials. “This operation highlights the seamless cooperation between Indian agencies and our international partners,” a CBI spokesperson noted.

This extradition is not an isolated event. On the same day, the CBI also secured the return of Kamlesh Parekh, a key accused in a staggering ₹2,672-crore bank fraud case linked to the Kolkata-based Shree Ganesh Jewellery House (I) Ltd. Parekh, a promoter of the firm, allegedly cheated a consortium of 25 banks led by the State Bank of India. Both operations underscore the UAE's growing role as a reliable partner in India's fight against economic offenders and organised crime.

India-UAE extradition ties have strengthened significantly in recent years, aided by a robust bilateral treaty and enhanced intelligence-sharing. Officials report that over 150 fugitives have been repatriated in recent times, dealing a blow to criminal networks that once viewed the Gulf as a haven. Passport forgery rackets, particularly in Haryana, have long been a concern for law enforcement as they enable gangsters and their aides to flee justice and operate transnationally.

Cases such as those involving gangsters who escaped using fake passports from Delhi's Regional Passport Office have exposed vulnerabilities in the system. Accused Aalok Kumar is expected to provide crucial leads in dismantling the broader forgery network.

Haryana Police will now interrogate him to uncover associates, beneficiaries, and the full extent of the racket. Legal proceedings against Kumar are underway, with authorities emphasising that no one involved in undermining national documents will escape accountability.

iranian official hints at renewed conflict

Tehran, however, continues to insist its nuclear program is strictly for peaceful purposes.

An unnamed senior Iranian official described the proposal as a “significant shift” intended to break the deadlock. Under the plan, hostilities would cease in exchange for assurances that neither the United States nor Israel would

resume attacks. Iran would reopen the Strait of Hormuz, while future negotiations would address nuclear restrictions and sanctions relief.

Crucially, Iran is seeking recognition of its right to enrich uranium for civilian use, even if it agrees to temporarily suspend such activities.

“Negotiations over the more complicated nuclear issue have been moved to the final stage to create a more conducive atmosphere,” the official said, emphasising a strategy to first stabilise the situation before tackling more contentious issues.

Despite these overtures, the rejection from Washington underscores the deep divide that remains. With both sides holding firm on key demands, prospects for a diplomatic breakthrough appear uncertain — and the risk of renewed conflict continues to grow.

SC backs EC on counting staff, no relief to TMC

The Election Commission assured the court that the circular would be implemented in letter and spirit, and there would be State Government employees also during the counting of votes on May 4.

Kapil Sibal, appearing for the TMC, said the circular was dated April 13, but they came to know about it on April 29. He said there are four issues: one, the circular appointing Central employees was issued to DEOs on April 13, but came to their knowledge only on April 29; two, the Election Commission says it has apprehensions of irregularity, despite having a Central nominee in the counting process; three, the poll body already has a Central Government officer at each counting table in the form of a micro observer, and four, the commission has not appointed State nominees even though the circular provides so.

Sibal submitted that the Chief Electoral Officer's communication states that there are apprehensions expressed from various quarters regarding possible irregularities in counting.

“That is like pointing a finger at the State Government...” Sibal said, adding, “There must be some data. Where is (the proof of) the apprehension (raised) from each booth? They have not disclosed this. And why not tell us that they are going to have a Central Government nominee?”

The bench, which held a special sitting, told Sibal that even if the Election Commission's circular had provided for the appointment of Central employees as both the counting supervisor and the counting assistant, the court could not have faulted the decision.

“The option is open for the Election Commission: whether the counting supervisor and assistant may be of the Central or the State Government. When that option is open, we cannot hold that the notification is contrary to regulations. Even if the EC says that both of them can be Central Government employees, we could not have faulted them. Because regulations say that either the Central Government or State Government officers can be appointed,” Justice Bagchi told Sibal.

Sibal then submitted that the court may ask the Election Commission to follow the impugned circular in its entirety, which provides for a State Government nominee. “All we want is, in terms of the circular, the state Government nominee should be there,” he said. Justice Bagchi asked if he wants compliance with the circular, then why is the TMC before the court.

Senior advocate DS Naidu, appearing for the Election Commission, submitted that the returning officer is a State Government employee with overarching power to deploy personnel from any pool of Government employees. “We are saying that there will be State Government employees during the counting of votes,” Naidu submitted, adding that each candidate will also have their own counting agent. “The TMC's apprehension of any wrongdoing is completely misplaced,” he reiterated.

The bench then disposed of the plea, saying that no further order is necessary and reiterated that the Election Commission will follow its circular in letter and spirit.

ED declares 21 fugitives under FEOA in 7 years

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has declared 21 individuals as Fugitive Economic Offenders (FEOs) over the past seven years under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act (FEOA), 2018, according to its latest annual report released on May 2, 2026.

The FEOA, enacted in 2018 by the Parliament of India, targets high-value economic offenders, involving proceeds of crime of ₹100 crore or more, who flee India to evade arrest warrants for scheduled offences under laws like the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). FEOA was then said to be a pivotal shift in India's approach to combating economic crimes, especially the offenders evading India's legal system. Once declared by a special PMLA court, their properties can be confiscated and vested with the Central Government, even without a conviction. This empowers the ED to freeze, seize and sell assets while pursuing extradition through international cooperation.

As per the annual report, the ED has initiated FEOA



proceedings against 54 individuals to date.

Of the 21 declared FEOs, nine were designated in the financial year 2025-26 alone. The agency has confiscated assets worth approximately ₹2,178.34 crore linked to these cases. This marks a significant increase from earlier figures (eg, around 14-15 declarations by late 2025), reflecting intensified enforcement in recent years by the ED.

Prominent names among the 21 include diamond merchant Nirav Modi involved in the ₹6,498 crore Punjab National Bank scam) and liquor baron Vijay Malviya, linked to the ₹7,505 crore Kingfisher Airlines loan default. Modi and Malviya fled to the UK years ago; extradi-

tion efforts are ongoing but protracted. UK-based arms consultant Sanjay Bhandari was declared an FEO in 2025. Bhandari fled India in 2016 after Income Tax raids, escaping via Nepal to London.

ED investigations revealed undisclosed foreign income of ₹655 crore and assets exceeding ₹100 crore, including properties in the UAE and UK. Bhandari allegedly routed funds through overseas shell companies between 2009 and 2016.

An Interpol Red Corner Notice was issued against Bhandari in 2017; the ED has filed prosecution complaints and is seeking confiscation of his properties.

Hajra Iqbal Memon (wife of late gangster Iqbal Mirchi, a close aide of Dawood

Ibrahim) was declared a fugitive earlier along with her sons Asif and Junaid in 2021. The case involves money laundering and proceeds linked to underworld activities; ED has moved to seize properties worth hundreds of crores. UK extradition proceedings faced hurdles but highlight cross-border challenges.

Other declared FEOs as per partial public lists of the ED, include members of the Sandesara family (Sterling Group), Jatin Mehta and recent additions like ex-MLC Mohammad Iqbal (declared March 2026, with ₹996 crore properties confiscated). High-profile cases against Mehul Choksi, Zakir Naik and Mahadev app promoters remain sub-judice.

"The ED's actions underscore a firm stance against economic offenders who exploit foreign safe havens, aiding asset recovery for banks and the exchequer while signalling zero tolerance for financial fugitives. Challenges persist in extradition and full recovery but the framework has strengthened India's anti-money laundering regime," an official said.

Shah stresses sustainable development in Ladakh



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Leh/Jammu

Union Home Minister Amit Shah stressed the need for a focused approach on sustainable development in Ladakh, with plantation and water security identified as key pillars for the region's overall progress, Ladakh LG VK Saxena said on Saturday. The LG apprised him of the ongoing work to create 50 water bodies in different villages under Project Him Sarovar and a recent plantation drive.

"While emphasising the spiritual nature of his visit to Leh on the pious occasion of Buddha Purnima, he urged a focused approach to sustainable development. Large-scale plantation and water security were identified by the home minister as key pillars for the overall development of Ladakh," Saxena said on X while sharing a post by the home minister.

Senior Ladakh leader Thupstan Chewang underscored the need to tap water from the Shyok river for drinking water and irrigation purposes.

Environmentalist Sonam Wangchuk said only around one per cent of glacial melt in Ladakh is currently utilised, while the rest goes

waste, and stressed the need for innovative methods to conserve it, the LG said.

Officials said that the Union Territory administration has already launched a large-scale drive to meet the twin objectives of plantation and water conservation to ensure climate-resilient development in Ladakh.

"I am pleased to share that in the last 40 days, more than 4500 trees of native species have already been planted across Leh and Kargil to promote environmental sustainability," the LG said.

Nearly 500 saplings of species such as bamboo, amaltas, gulmohar, jacaranda, bougainvillea, banyan, peepal and imli have also been planted in Leh on an experimental basis, he said.

As directed by Shah, the plantation exercise and water conservation efforts will be further intensified across the region, with authorities aiming to create at least 100 large water bodies over the next year. Officials said the long-term goal is to increase forest cover in Ladakh from less than one per cent at present to at least five per cent over the next two years.

Nation Focus



KV SINGH TO REPRESENT INDIA AT MIGRATION CONCLAVE IN US

Minister of State for External Affairs and Environment Kirti Vardhan Singh will represent India at a conclave on migration being hosted by the UN General Assembly in New York next week.

The second International Migration Review Forum (IMRF), beginning Monday, is expected to deliberate on crucial issues relating to migration and its intersection with Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

Singh will lead the Indian delegation for the IMRF, being held under the auspices of the General Assembly at the United Nations in New York from May 4 to 8, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Saturday.



GOVT APPOINTS TWO FULL-TIME MEMBERS OF NITI AAYOG

The Centre on Saturday appointed academician Joram Aniya and scholar-author R Balasubramaniam as full-time members of the Niti Aayog, taking the total number of such members in the Government think tank to seven, along with a vice-chairman. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is the chairman of the NITI Aayog. "In continuation of the Cabinet Secretariat's notification dated April 24, 2026, the prime minister has approved the appointment of the following persons as full-time members of the NITI Aayog with effect from the date of assumption of charge and until further orders, on the same terms and conditions as are applicable to full-time members: (i) Dr R Balasubramaniam; (ii) Dr Joram Aniya.

Rahul lambasts BJP over indecent remark against woman MP

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Coming down heavily on the BJP, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Saturday said its mask of "Nari Vandans" is off, exposing the saffron party's "anti-women and Manuwadi" mindset. In a post on X, Gandhi said the Gujarat BJP



president made an "indecent remark" on a woman Congress MP, Geniben Thakor. "The mask of 'Nari Vandana' is off. This isn't just shameful — it reveals the real face of the BJP's Manuwadi, anti-women ideology," Gandhi said.

The row stems from a remark made by Gujarat BJP chief Jagdish Vishwakhar, who

told a gathering in Banaskantha on Thursday that the BJP had taken control of the district panchayat after 30 years from the "pallu" of Thakor's sari. Questioning the BJP's commitment towards women's empowerment, Gandhi asked, "Is this the way BJP worships women? Will they empower women?"

Four personnel killed in explosion of gunpowder dump in Chhattisgarh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kanker

Four police personnel were killed in an explosion while trying to dispose of a gunpowder dump of Maoists in Chhattisgarh's Kanker district on Saturday, officials said.

This was the first explosion incident linked to Naxalites in the State since it was declared free from armed Maoism on March 31. It was also the first instance this year in which security personnel engaged in anti-Naxal operations lost their lives.

Police earlier said that an improvised explosive device (IED) had gone off while being neutralised, but later a senior official stated that it was a gunpowder dump, hidden by Maoists when they were active in the area.

The tragic incident took place at around 11.30 am in a forest area of Aadnar village under Chhotebethiya police station limits, near the Narayanpur district border, when a joint team of security personnel was conducting a demining operation to locate and defuse IEDs planted earlier by Naxalites, Inspector General of Police (Bastar Range) Sundarraj Pattilingam said.

Based on the inputs received from surrendered Maoists and other intelli-



Representative Image PTI

gence, security forces have recovered and neutralised hundreds of IEDs across the Bastar range, he said.

Saturday's operation was launched following similar inputs about concealed Maoist dumps in the Chhotebethiya area. The team, led by the police's District Reserve Guard, also included personnel from the Bastar Fighters, the IG said.

The police team first found a dump containing items such as a computer and a printer. Then another nearby dump containing five sacks (about 15 kg each) of explosive firecracker powder — gunpowder comprising potassium nitrate and barium nitrate — was found, the official said.

With the assistance of a Bomb Disposal Squad (BDS), the team leader and other members were removing the material. It is suspected that it exploded due to high temperature and a possible chemical reaction, the IG said.

Prasoon Joshi appointed chairman of Prasar Bharati

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Noted lyricist, writer and communications expert Prasoon Joshi has been appointed as the chairman of Prasar Bharati, India's public service broadcaster.

The Ministry of Information & Broadcasting appointed Joshi to the key post, according to an official statement on Saturday.

Joshi, a distinguished creative professional with wide-ranging contributions across literature, advertising, cinema, and public communication, and known for his impactful writing and deep cultural sensibility, has played a significant role in shaping contemporary



Indian media narratives, the statement said.

Joshi's body of work spans acclaimed film lyrics, advertising campaigns, and socially resonant storytelling that connects with diverse audiences across the country.

On his appointment, Union Minister of Information & Broadcasting

Ashwini Vaishnav said, "My heartfelt congratulations to Shri Prasoon Joshi ji on his appointment as chairman of the Prasar Bharati Board. Prasoon ji is a rare creative spirit celebrated across the world in advertising, literature, art and cinema, yet his heart beats unmistakably for India."

Key associate arrested in Shambhu track blast case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

Punjab Police have arrested Gurjinder Singh alias Baba Beant, described as a key associate of the main executor in the Shambhu railway track blast case. The arrest marks a breakthrough in the investigation into a series of terror-related incidents targeting critical infrastructure in the State.

The joint operation was conducted by the State Special Operations Cell (SSOC), Amritsar, Patiala Police, and Counter Intelligence (CI) Pathankot.



Gaurav Yadav, DGP Punjab Police, said, "Gurjinder Singh was apprehended in connection with the April 27, 2026, low-intensity IED blast on the Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) railway track near Bathonia village in Patiala district, close to the Punjab-Haryana border."

Preliminary investigations have linked the accused to multiple attacks, including the Shambhu blast, the Sirhind railway track blast in January 2026, and a grenade attack on the Counter-Intelligence Agency (CIA) office in Moga. All incidents were allegedly executed under the direction of foreign-based handlers, with the module reportedly backed by cross-border elements, including Pakistan's ISI and pro-Khalistan networks.

"With this arrest and earlier recoveries, all three terror-related incidents in

Moga, Sirhind and Shambhu are successfully solved," the DGP said, adding that the Punjab Police is committed to dismantling terror networks, noting that the operation reflects the vigilance and efficiency of Punjab's security forces in maintaining peace, security and law and order.

The incident occurred on the night of April 27, 2026, when an IED detonated prematurely while being planted on the freight railway track in the Shambhu-Ambala section. The blast created a small crater and minor damage

but caused no disruption to passenger services. The main perpetrator, Jagroop Singh alias Jupa, a 35-year-old resident of Panjwar village in Tarn Taran district, was killed in the explosion. His badly charred body was recovered at the site. The body was identified by the police swiftly through forensic evidence.

Within hours, Patiala Police arrested four accomplices, Pardeep Singh Khalsa the alleged module leader, Kulwinder Singh alias Banga, Satnam Singh alias Satta and Gurpreet Singh alias Gopi.

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Centre insensitive to common man: Telangana Congress



Bandi Sudhakar Goud

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Congress on Saturday said the sudden increase of commercial LPG cylinder prices up to ₹1,000 immediately after the completion of elections in five States reflects the peak level of insensitivity of the Central Government leadership.

"We demand to know what answer the BJP leaders — who preach morality and nationalism every day — have for the people of this country. This clearly shows that the central BJP leadership is more focused on elections and revenue collections rather than addressing the problems faced by the people," said Telangana Congress spokesman Bandi Sudhakar Goud.

In a statement, he said increasing prices right after elections raises serious questions about their intent and commitment.

CTUs urge Yogi to release workers, revise minimum wages

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow/New Delhi

A joint platform of Central Trade Unions (CTUs) has written to Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, expressing "deep anguish and restlessness" over the deteriorating plight of workers in the National Capital Region (NCR) and other industrial hubs. In a formal representation, the unions highlighted a massive wave of protests sparked by stagnant wages and alleged police atrocities against agitating labourers.

The unions — including INTUC, AITUC, HMS, CITU,



AIUTUC, TUCC, SEWA, AICTUC, LPF, UTUC — pointed out that minimum wages in the State have not been revised for over a decade, despite specific mandates in the Minimum Wages Act. This stagnation, coupled with the soaring prices of essential commodities, education, and healthcare, has

made it "hard to meet the minimum basic needs of families," the letter stated.

The CTUs further alleged a complete breakdown of labour laws in industrial units, citing the absence of occupational safety, forced 12 to 13-hour shifts without overtime payment, and the denial of leave. They also raised the issue of "ill-treatment" of the women workforce, which they claimed is "offending their dignity."

"Industrial peace is in jeopardy not because of workers but because of the non-compliance of existing laws by the employers," the joint statement read. The unions con-

demned the recent administrative crackdown, alleging that union leaders were placed under house arrest while police committed "humiliations and atrocities" on protesters.

The platform urged the Chief Minister to take a "lenient view" and ensure the immediate release of arrested workers to provide relief to their suffering families. They also called for the urgent constitution of a Minimum Wages Board for a "scientific calculation" of pay scales, noting that recent Government-announced increases fell far below worker expectations.

CPI(M) slams Govt over steep hike in LPG prices

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Saturday launched a scathing attack on the Modi Government following a steep hike in the prices of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) cylinders, labelling the move as "cruel" and "anti-poor." The party has demanded an immediate withdrawal of the revised rates and called for nationwide protests.

Expressing deep concern over the unprecedented surge in the cost of commercial gas cylinders — which have seen a sharp increase of nearly one thousand rupees — the Left party warned of a severe "cascading effect" on the economy. "Commercial establishments are bound to pass on the lia-



bility to the consumers, further adding to their burdens and fuelling inflation," the Polit Bureau stated in an official communique. It further cautioned

that many small-scale enterprises would be forced to shut down, leading to massive layoffs and job losses.

The CPI(M) particularly highlighted the plight of small households and migrant labourers, noting that while 14-kg domestic cylinders have been spared for now, the price of 5-kg non-subsidised cylinders has been hiked by ₹261. "This cruel hike for the 5-kg cylinders will most adversely impact migrant workers and small households who cannot afford the larger 14-kg cylinders," the statement read.

According to the party, this is the second such "hefty increase" in commercial rates in the past two months. The Polit Bureau alleged that the Centre's refusal to forego tax revenue on essential cylinders exposes its "anti-poor bias."



BIHAR GOVT UNDER NITISH'S GUIDANCE: VIJAY CHOUDHARY

Bihar Deputy CM Vijay Kumar Choudhary on Saturday said the Samrat Choudhary Government was working under the guidance of Nitish Kumar. Addressing a press conference at the JD(U) headquarters in Patna, he said the Opposition was trying to raise a false alarm that communalism was rife under the BJP-led NDA Government in the State. "Chief Minister Choudhary has time and again clarified that the present Government is being run under the guidance of Nitish Kumar, and that there will be zero-tolerance towards communalism," he said. "A fabricated perception has been created by Opposition parties that the BJP ignites communalism. On the contrary, during their own rule in the State, they projected themselves as protectors of minorities while doing nothing for their upliftment," he claimed.



MASS PROTEST IN BENGAL OVER TMC WORKERS' THREATS

Demanding safety after counting of votes, hundreds of villagers staged a protest in Falta in West Bengal's South 24 Parganas district on Saturday, alleging they were receiving life threats from TMC workers in the area. The protesters, many of them women and holding BJP flags, blocked the road in Hasimnagar village, alleging that local panchayat pradhan Israfil, a close associate of TMC candidate Jehangir Khan, issued them threats of attacks after poll results are announced. The CRPF deputy commandant visited the area with a large force and assured the demonstrators of ensuring their safety.

Vibrant Gujarat Conference: 2,792 MoUs worth ₹3.53 lakh crore signed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Surat

The Gujarat Government has signed 2,792 memoranda of understanding (MoUs) of ₹3,53,306 crore during the two-day Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference for South Gujarat, and the projects are expected to generate 2.82 lakh direct job opportunities in the coming years. State Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi provided this information during the conference's valedictory function in Surat. "In these two days at the South Gujarat conference, we have achieved massive milestones: 2,792 MoUs were signed, and investments worth ₹3,53,306 crore were pledged on the soil of South Gujarat," he said. Once these projects are



Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi addressing the valedictory session of the Vibrant Gujarat Regional Conference – South Gujarat at AURO University in Surat, Gujarat

implemented over the next three years, they will create large-scale job opportunities, he said. "These projects will provide direct employment to 2.82 lakh youths in the region," Sanghavi said. Before this regional conference in Surat, two similar events were held in the

recent past: first in Mehsana for the North Gujarat region and second at Rajkot for the Saurashtra and Kutch region. According to Sanghavi, the State Government has taken the Vibrant Gujarat initiative beyond the State Capital, Gandhinagar, to different regions so that more people can benefit from it.

MP boat tragedy: Search operations expanded as four still missing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jabalpur

Army divers and disaster response teams on Saturday expanded their search at Bargi Dam in Madhya Pradesh to locate a man and three children still missing after the cruise boat tragedy that claimed nine lives two days ago, officials said. With 28 of the 41 identified passengers onboard the ill-fated cruise boat rescued safely, police are preparing to register an FIR in connection with the accident that



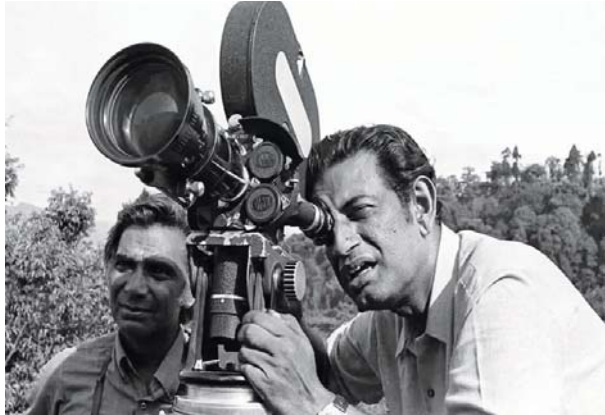
occurred at the reservoir in Jabalpur district on Thursday evening, they said. The search radius has been expanded to 5 km in the backwaters of the Bargi Dam, located downstream of the Narmada River, area

sub-divisional officer of police (SDOP) Anjul Ayank Mishra said. Nine people drowned in the incident, while 28 were rescued, and efforts are ongoing to trace the missing persons, he said. According to the police, more than 200 rescuers, including around 20 Army divers airlifted from Agra, began the search operation at 5 am on Saturday to trace Kamraj, an employee of the Ordnance Factory in Khamaria, his son Tamil (5), Vijay Soni (6) and Mayuram (5).

Tributes pour in for Satyajit Ray on 105th birth anniversary

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Saturday said the timeless creations of film maestro Satyajit Ray will remain an invaluable treasure to the world of cinema. Hundreds of people from across the State and even outside flocked to the legendary filmmaker's 1 Bishop Lefroy Road residence here on his 105th birth anniversary and paid tributes as his son



Sandip Ray and other members of the family warmly greeted them. "The immortal works of Ray will remain as an invaluable treasure in world cinema," Banerjee said in a post on X, remembering one of India's greatest cinematic legends. To a question, his director son Sandip Ray said the initiative to preserve the maestro's vast creative legacy through restoration and digitisation of his large volume of works is already continuing by the Society for the

Preservation of Satyajit Ray Films. "The work is happening overseas as well as here. I feel it is extremely necessary because preservation is important," he said. He added that efforts are being made to digitise a large collection of documents related to the legendary filmmaker's work. "We are already working on plans to digitise the papers. There is a vast body of materials, from sketches to writings. We are very busy

handling all of it," he added. However, Sandip clarified that there are no immediate plans to work on adaptations of Feluda, one of Ray's most iconic literary creations. "At present, there is no such thought. I would prefer to focus on short stories for now," he said. Ray, born in Kolkata on May 2, 1921, remains a towering figure in world cinema, celebrated for his humanistic storytelling, realism and artistic depth that transcended borders and cultures.

Mamata, Abhishek meet TMC counting agents

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Saturday told counting agents of the party during a meeting that it will secure over 200 of the 294 Assembly seats, two days ahead of the counting of votes polled. The two leaders, who held a virtual meeting with counting agents of 291 Assembly seats, also told them that they should regularly update the leadership about the prevailing situation at counting centres and must remain there till the end of the exercise. The Anit Thapa-led Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha (BGP) contested the remaining three seats in the Darjeeling hills. The two-phase Assembly polls were held on April 23

and April 29, with counting of votes scheduled for May 4. The CM, who asserted that the "TMC will at least win 200-plus seats if not more", also asked counting agents not to give importance to the "propaganda and campaign by the BJP and its allies" about the number of seats they would secure. She said that the TMC will stand beside counting agents who had been allegedly assaulted by central forces during voting or campaigning. "Do not give importance to the numerous exit polls telecast on TV channels and the social media," she told the agents, according to a senior TMC leader. "Such exit polls have no value. The 2021 and 2024 exit polls were way off the mark. I think most such polls are meant to influence the share market," the TMC supremo said. She also said that in case of



any TMC candidate losing a seat by "a margin of 200-300 votes", the counting agents must insist on recounting. "No one should leave the counting centres till the process is over," the chief minister said. Abhishek Banerjee, who also interacted with the counting agents virtually, asked them to insist on recounting, particularly for

postal ballots, in case of defeat of TMC nominees by a narrow margin. "All unusual activities inside counting centres, like the sudden power outage at the Nandigram counting centre in 2021, must be immediately reported to the party's top brass," he said. The virtual meeting, which began at 4 pm, lasted for nearly two hours.

TMC MOVES ECI ALLEGING UNAUTHORISED POSTAL BALLOT SORTING

Kolkata: The TMC on Saturday said it has filed a complaint with the Election Commission of India (ECI), alleging unauthorised sorting of postal ballot covers at an EVM strongroom in Kolkata. TMC workers, who have been camping outside the Khudiram Anushilan Kendra, alleged that eight trunks of postal ballots were brought in at 4 am and were taken to a room, which has no CCTV coverage. "We have been demanding that every single millimetre of space where EVMs and postal ballots be under CCTV surveillance. But as these trunks were taken inside, it was clear that they were taken to a room not under CCTV cover. Why should this happen?" a TMC member asked. Voting machines from several Assembly segments of northern and eastern Kolkata are stored at the strongroom at Khudiram Anushilan Kendra. As TMC activists were demonstrating, BJP's Shyampukur candidate Purnima Chakraborty reached the spot with her supporters, escalating tensions. Both sides started shouting slogans as police stood between them, attempting to bring the situation under control. Chakraborty claimed that sensing defeat, TMC workers were creating chaos outside the strongroom. Later, the TMC said it filed a complaint with the EC over the issue. Similar scenes were witnessed outside the strongroom at the Barasat Government College in North 24 Parganas district, where TMC workers demonstrated, alleging that the CCTV was switched off for 17 minutes in the morning.

BJP accuses Kejriwal of vendetta as MP Sandeep Pathak booked

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

The BJP on Saturday accused AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal of indulging in vendetta politics and misusing the Punjab Police after two FIRs were registered against Rajya Sabha MP Sandeep Pathak, who recently defected to the party along with six others. It also alleged that law and order in the State has deteriorated. BJP national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi claimed that the police action reflects misplaced priorities. "Punjab Police went to Pathak's residence and attempted to carry out a raid. We want to ask if the law and order situation has become so weak that the police are unable to act against drug traffickers, but are being used in this manner?" he told reporters. Targeting Kejriwal and Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, Trivedi said, "Those who claim to represent a new kind of politics should explain how, in their state, law and order has completely collapsed." Referring to the Opposition's allegation that Mann was under the influence of alcohol in the Punjab Assembly on Friday, Trivedi accused the AAP Government of failing to maintain governance. "I want to clearly say to the AAP, the Punjab Government, and especially Kejriwal that this is a fragile facade," he said. Another BJP national spokesperson, Shehzad



Former AAP MP Sandeep Pathak, who recently joined the BJP is seen leaving his residence shortly before Punjab Police arrived to serve notices in two newly registered non-bailable FIRs in New Delhi on Saturday

Poonawalla, claimed that Kejriwal is misusing the Punjab Police to settle political scores, and Mann has become a party to it. "Two FIRs have been filed against Sandeep Pathak, who until recently was in the Aam Aadmi Party as a Rajya Sabha MP and general secretary (organisation). What is baffling is the shameless, brazen vendetta politics being pursued by Arvind Kejriwal, with Bhagwant Mann complicit in it," Poonawalla said on X. "It is clear this has been done out of vendetta politics by Kejriwal, who is extremely vengeful and vindictive, and misuses the Punjab Police to pursue such political vendetta," he alleged in the post. Questioning the timing of the FIRs, Poonawalla asked, "If these cases existed from the beginning, why were FIRs not filed earlier? If he was corrupt, why was he kept in the party for so long, especially when he was the general secretary (organisation)? Has any new material surfaced in the last few days, or has the

alleged corruption occurred only now?" He alleged that Kejriwal has an "old habit" of targeting political opponents and dissenters. "We have seen how he has used the police against rivals, including Congress leaders. This is his old habit," Poonawalla said, referring to the withdrawal of Rajya Sabha MP Harbhajan Singh's security. He claimed that several leaders who had left AAP over the years, including Yogendra Yadav, Mayank Gandhi, Ashish Khetan, Ashutosh and Alka Lamba, were "hounded". The BJP leader accused the AAP of failing to introspect. "Instead of introspecting on how they have changed - from Anna to Lalu, from Lokpal to corruption - they are indulging in vendetta politics, trying to victimise people using the strong arm of the law. This reflects an Emergency-like mindset and a dictatorial, Hitlerian mindset," he said. The State party leaders have also condemned the action against Pathak.

Exit polls manipulated by BJP to mislead voters: Gaurav Gogoi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

Assam Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi on Saturday alleged that exit polls are being manipulated by the BJP to create confusion among voters. Addressing a press conference after a meeting of Opposition alliance leaders in Guwahati, Gogoi said the BJP may try to mislead people, but will not succeed. "Neither the opposition parties nor the people of the state have fallen into the trap of exit polls, and this will be evident on the day of counting on May 4," he said. Gogoi said there is a "silent vote" and an "undercurrent" in favour of the opposition, which exit poll surveys have not captured. Many voters, especially women, have



Gaurav Gogoi during the party observers meeting in Guwahati on Saturday

voted based on real issues like price rise and governance, he claimed. Gogoi alleged that the BJP has been trying to create anomalies in the strongrooms, but our candidates and alert public have gone to the administration on several occasions to prevent such misdeeds.

Man held in Gujarat for promoting ISIS ideology on social media

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi/Ahmedabad

Gujarat Police have arrested Fakirmamad Isha Gagda a 32-year-old resident of Lodai village in Bhuj taluka, Kutch district, for allegedly spreading the ideology of the banned terrorist organisation ISIS through social media.



According to Gujarat Police officials, Gagda was running separate accounts on Instagram and Facebook for nearly four years. He regularly posted inflammatory content glorifying 'Islamic war', the establishment of a caliphate (Khilafat) and jihad, thereby inciting people against India's sovereignty, unity and territorial integrity. The West Kutch-Bhuj Special Operations Group (SOG) acted on specific intelligence about suspicious anti-national activity originating from Lodai village. During the operation, police seized his mobile phone and recovered direct evidence of the offending posts and related material. Investigators are now conducting intensive interrogation to identify any wider network, foreign or domestic contacts, or handlers behind the online radicalisation campaign. Senior

security agencies are also assisting in the probe. The arrest of Fakairmand, denotes ongoing vigilance by Gujarat police against online radicalisation, especially in the sensitive border region of Kutch. No other individuals have been named in connection with the case so far. "His posts were not isolated incidents. Investigators believe the accused had been sharing such material consistently for nearly four years," police sources said. The posts allegedly called for 'Islamic war', glorified the caliphate and invoked jihad. A case has been registered at Paddhar Police Station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for promoting anti-national activities and incitement. Digital devices have been seized and sent for forensic examination.

PROSPECT

India needs strategic buffers to navigate energy shock: CEA Nageswaran



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Economic Advisor V Anantha Nageswaran on Saturday said India needs to create strategic buffers in the face of the “most difficult” energy shock that the country is facing amid the West Asia crisis.

Nageswaran also said the rising prices of fertiliser and petroleum products globally due to the crisis will make it challenging to achieve the 4.3 per cent fiscal deficit target for the current fiscal, while below normal monsoon and pass-through of higher energy prices could lead to “potential inflation spike”.

He also said India has employment challenge emanating from AI, and there is a need to ensure that IT sector becomes more competitive and not lose jobs to AI, and instead create jobs that use AI within the IT sector or in other services.

Speaking at the ICPG Growth Conference organised by the Ashoka University, Nageswaran said the current account deficit (CAD) in the current fiscal could rise to over 2 per cent of GDP, from less than 1 per

cent in FY’26.

“The ... priority for us is to create strategic buffers. This energy shock is the most difficult one compared to any other previous energy shock in terms of energy lost as a percentage of total global energy supply, not just oil, including gas.” And we also need to use this occasion to think about other areas where we are vulnerable in terms of import dependence, nickel, tin, and copper. We need to build strategic buffers if we have to make a shot at manufacturing and becoming indispensable,” Nageswaran said.

Since the beginning of the war in West Asia on February 28, crude oil prices soared to a four-year high of \$126 per barrel on Thursday, from about \$73 level before the war.

Stating that geopolitics will compel policymakers to be nimble and flexible and shed old model of thinking, Nageswaran said India is better prepared than many other countries to deal with the crisis because of the fiscal leeway that the country has due to lowering of fiscal deficit ratio to 4.4 per cent of GDP in FY’26.

India’s energy security starts at home



KRISHNA MOHAN PUVVADA

The latest conflict in the Middle East has underscored a persistent reality: energy security remains a vital concern that cannot be taken for granted. For India, which imports 87 per cent of its crude oil, much of it from this region: The lesson is particularly significant. When you add to that 60 per cent of its LPG imports, every kilogram of potash used for agriculture, and nearly half the petrochemicals found in everyday products like detergents, plastics, and solvents, the extent of India’s exposure becomes unmistakably clear.

This dependence on far-flung, often volatile supply routes is a strategic vulnerability that no amount of diplomatic maneuvering can fully safeguard. India has already demonstrated its capacity to reduce import reliance,

as seen in the Ethanol Blended Petrol Programme.

Remarkably, the country achieved 20 per cent blending five years ahead of schedule, saving ₹1,44,000 crores in foreign exchange, paying ₹1,25,000 crores directly to farmers, and generating about 165,000 jobs. This success was powered by strong political will and robust policy measures that encouraged private sector investment in new ethanol production facilities.

Collaboration among engineering companies, biosolution technology providers, academia, and regulatory bodies fostered an ecosystem that built trust and enabled transformative change. This model, proven to work, is ready to be scaled up. Fossil dependence is often seen as a fuel issue, but it is much more pervasive.

Fertilizers, chemical intermediates, industrial raw materials, and a wide array of products that drive India’s economy still hinge on fossil-based imports.

However, alternatives can be produced domestically and sustainably using biosolutions. Currently, India boasts a surplus bio-ethanol capacity of 7–8 billion liters, which

can be harnessed for innovative applications.

Enzymes and microorganisms can transform local biomass, crops, and agricultural residues into fuels, chemicals, and materials that are viable substitutes for fossil-based products.

With the right technologies and policies, and with current excess production capacity, ethanol has the potential for up to 8 per cent commercial LPG substitution. Sustainable aviation fuels, biodiesel, and biochemicals are transitioning from aspiration to reality, with infrastructure already advancing.

Beyond fuel, biofertilisers offer promising ways to reduce reliance on fossil and synthetic agricultural inputs. For example, our assessments show that in rice cultivation, agricultural biosolutions can cut phosphorus (DAP) usage by 25 per cent and urea consumption by 30 per cent.

A policy that incentivizes biologicals as much as chemical fertilizers would encourage widespread adoption among farmers. Every rupee invested in home-grown biosolutions stays in India, multiplying domestic income, creating rural jobs, and strengthening economic independence and security.

While the technological groundwork, proof of concepts, and raw materials are in place, regulatory processes need to evolve rapidly to keep pace with these innovations.

Clearer guidelines and expedited approvals will unlock further investment in this exciting space. India has shown it can set ambitious goals and surpass them.

Now, the opportunity is to extend that determination across the broader fossil value chain—not only for fuel, but also for what goes into kitchens, fields, and factories. India is well-positioned to lead the biosolutions revolution.

Technology is ready and with ongoing innovation, today’s challenges can be turned into tomorrow’s opportunities. The crisis in the Middle East will not be the last of its kind, but by building resilience at home, India can secure its future regardless of external disruptions. Biosolutions are central to this vision.

Author is a renowned energy expert and seasoned global business leader with over three decades of experience spanning Asia-Pacific, the Middle East, Africa and South Asia. Author is an alumni of Sri Satya Sai Institute of Higher Education

Army neutralises suspected explosive in Manipur



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

On April 30, 2026 during a routine patrol in the vicinity of Mouslang village in Churachandpur district, Manipur, troops of the Indian Army detected a suspected explosive device in the area, posing a potential threat to civilian lives in the area.

Based on the inputs, the



Engineers of the Red Shield Division swiftly mobilised a Bomb Disposal Team to the location. The area was cordoned and all necessary safety precautions were put in place. The presence of explosives was confirmed with the help of an Explosive Detector Dog to enable an accurate assessment of the threat.

The Bomb Disposal Team

carried out an in-situ destruction of the suspected Unexploded Ordinance of an old vintage, in a controlled manner, neutralising the threat without any collateral damage.

This successful operation reaffirms the Indian Army’s unwavering commitment to safeguarding civilian lives and preserving peace and security in the region.

Dog Home Foundation deploys water safety net for animals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jodhpur

Dog Home Foundation has installed over 10,000 water tanks, locally known as khelis, across Jodhpur to help animals cope with summer temperatures that often soar to 45°C.

Using scientific mapping, the foundation identified “high-risk” dry zones—areas with little to no natural water availability—and prioritised them for tank installation.

Veterinary experts associated with the project report significant health benefits. Continuous access to water has reduced cases of heat-stroke and dehydration among strays by an estimated 80 per cent during peak summer months.

Authorities and volunteers have observed a noticeable decline in animal aggression and a reduction in road acci-



dents linked to distressed strays wandering in search of water.

Actor John Abraham, who was in Jodhpur during the filming of Veda, visited the foundation after rescuing an injured dog. He praised the organisation’s round-the-clock emergency ambulance service and its specialised medical facilities, calling them a benchmark for urban animal care.

A key pillar of the project’s

success is its zero-maintenance model, driven entirely by public participation. Local shopkeepers voluntarily refill water tanks each day as they open their businesses, while children and young volunteers help clean and monitor the units in their neighborhoods. This decentralised approach has ensured sustainability without imposing recurring operational costs.

Ai+ smartphone announces return of sales for Nova 2 5G and Nova 2 Ultra 5G sale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ai+ Smartphone has announced the return of sales for its popular Nova Series devices—the Nova 2 5G and Nova 2 Ultra 5G—starting May 1, exclusively on Flipkart and select retail outlets. Following strong consumer demand during previous sale cycles, the brand is once again making both smartphones available to meet growing interest.

The Ai+ Nova 2 5G is priced at ₹9,999, while the Ai+ Nova 2 Ultra 5G is available at ₹16,999.

Commenting on the

announcement, Madhav Sheth, CEO of Ai+ Smartphone and Founder of NxtQuantum Shift Technologies, said the strong response to the Nova lineup reflects increasing demand for smartphones that combine reliability with meaningful innovation.

The Nova 2 5G is built for everyday performance, featuring a 6000mAh battery, 6.745-inch HD+ 120Hz adaptive display, 50MP rear camera, 8MP front camera, IP64 resistance, side-mounted fingerprint sensor, and runs on Android 16 with NxtQuantum OS.

The Nova 2 Ultra 5G offers

a premium experience powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 7400 chipset, paired with a 6.78-inch 1.5K AMOLED 120Hz display, 50MP Sony IMX752 primary camera, 8MP ultra-wide lens, 13MP selfie camera, IP68 rating, 40W fast charging, and expandable storage up to 1TB.

The Ultra variant also includes a power adapter, Type-C cable, and NovaPods Edge in the box. Ai+ Smartphone continues strengthening its position as a design-led, privacy-first Indian smartphone brand powered by India’s sovereign NxtQuantum OS.

Govt appoints Rohit Jain as RBI Deputy Governor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has appointed Rohit Jain as Deputy Governor of the Reserve Bank of India for a three-year term.

Jain is replacing T Rabi Sankar, whose extended tenure ended on Saturday.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has approved his appointment for a period of three years from the date of joining the post on or after May 3, sources said on Saturday.

Jain is currently Executive Director at the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

According to the RBI Act, 1934, the central bank should have four deputy governors,” two from within the ranks, one commercial banker and an economist to head the monetary policy department.



The other three deputy governors are Swaminathan J, Poonam Gupta and S C Murmu.

Rabi Sankar was first appointed Deputy Governor in September 2021 for three years and was given a one-year extension in 2024 and subsequently in 2025.

High-level panel on banking to oversee banks’ balance sheet constraints: DFS Secretary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju on Friday said the High-Level Committee on Banking for Viksit Bharat will look into public sector banks’ balance sheet constraints to leverage their capital. The Government is likely to announce the terms of reference for the panel.

“This committee is expected to review the banking sector with a focus on making it more effective, more inclusive, and better aligned with India’s growth needs, while maintaining financial stability,” he said at the ICPG Growth Conference here.

“We will also likely examine intermediation cost, balance sheet constraints in banks and areas where regulators and institutions can improve the flow of credit,” he added.

Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman had proposed setting up a high-level committee on banking to comprehensively review the banking sector. “I propose setting up a ‘High Level Committee on



Banking for Viksit Bharat’ to comprehensively review the sector and align it with India’s next phase of growth, while safeguarding financial stability, inclusion and consumer protection,” she had said in the Budget speech on February 1, 2026.

On the deepening bond market, Nagaraju said, India needs to develop its corporate bond market so that companies that are not top-rated also get access to capital.

“We need to seriously deepen India’s corporate bond market. Banks are not the right vehicle for long-term financing. They have a maturity constraint. They cannot comfortably lend for 10 or 20 years when their deposits are short-term. A well-functioning bond market

fills that gap,” he said. It provides companies a direct route to long-term capital, improves price discovery and creates competition that keeps borrowing costs honest across the system, he said.

Observing that 90-95 per cent of bond issuances from companies are AA or above rated, Nagaraju said the bulk of the US market is A and BBB rated, whereas there is a gap in the middle tier of the bond market segment in India.

Therefore, he said, companies face difficulty in raising funds in long-duration tenors, and long-term capital borrowers must tap the corporate bond market for funds. “The ability of long-term institutional investors to participate more actively in the corporate bond market will be an important factor in deter-

mining how deep and liquid that market can become. “The supply side needs to develop better secondary market liquidity, lower transaction friction, and greater coherence in how similar instruments are treated across different regulatory frameworks. The bond, the currency, and the derivatives markets need to work together effectively,” Nagaraju said.

Financial sector regulators, the Government, and the high-level committee on banking will have to consider the interlinkages with the banking sector at large, he further said.

“Beyond the market structure itself, the cost of capital ultimately reflects broader economic fundamentals. The quality of fiscal management, the stability of the monetary

environment, and the confidence of the investor, that policy will be consistent and predictable,” he said.

Nagaraju stressed that a well-functioning bond market gives companies a direct route to long-term capital, improves price discovery, and creates competition that keeps borrower costs honest across the system.

“Deepening the bond market is not just a task for any single institution. It requires coordinated action across regulators and across the Government. The demand side needs to expand,” he said.

Nagaraju also underscored the need for capital to reach last-mile borrowers at competitive rates. “If capital reaches only the most credit-worthy borrowers, the finan-

cial system is doing its job at a basic level. If it also reaches those who are viable, but currently underserved, the system is working efficiently,” Nagaraju said.

It is important that the financial system efficiently mobilises private savings towards the productive use, he said. “The question is not just whether capital is available. It is whether capital is affordable for the farmer who needs crop finance, the small business that wants to expand, or the infrastructure project that needs long-term financing,” he said.

When the cost of borrowing is higher than the underlying risk of requirements, viable projects simply do not happen, he said.

This is felt most sharply by smaller businesses, first-generation entrepreneurs, and rural borrowers, he said.

He, however, warned that financial markets need stronger oversight and need “better regulation, not less regulation.”

“India’s own experience with the co-operative banks, non-banking financial companies, and parts of the micro-finance sector shows what can go wrong without it. What I am arguing for is better-designed regulation,” he added.

Finance Ministry notifies 100% FDI in insurance sector, amends FEMA Rules



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Finance Ministry on Saturday notified 100 per cent Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) in the insurance sector under the automatic route.

While 100 per cent foreign investment will be allowed in insurance companies and intermediaries, including brokers, under the automatic route, the cap is 20 per cent for Life Insurance Corporation (LIC), said the Foreign Exchange Management (Non-debt Instruments) (Second Amendment) Rules, 2026.

The Parliament had passed the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (amendment of insurance laws) Bill, 2025, in December, 2025, paving the way for hiking the FDI cap in the insurance sector to 100 per cent under the automatic route, from 74 per cent earlier. Subsequently, after the President’s assent, the Bill became law.

Thereafter in February, 2026, the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) under the Commerce and Industry Ministry had notified 100 per cent FDI in the insurance sector.



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FROM THE WORLD

MALI

Officers accused of treason

Some military officers in Mali worked with jihadists and separatists who recently launched their biggest round of attacks in over a decade in the conflict-battered country, authorities said. The separatist fighters, meanwhile, said earlier in the day that they captured a strategic military camp in the northern town of Tessalit after the withdrawal of Mali's army and its Russian allies from there. The claim by the Azawad Liberation Front separatist group was the latest setback for Mali's ruling junta, which lost control of the major city of Kidal earlier in the week as part of the attacks that killed Malian Defence Minister Sadio Camara. Mali has been run by the military since a 2020 coup and has long suffered violence as jihadi groups expand in surrounding territories in the wider Sahel region south of the Sahara Desert.

CROATIA

Fuel crisis hits tourism

Summer is still a few months away, but the streets of Croatia's old town of Dubrovnik are already teeming with tourists from all over the world. It's usually a sign of a strong season ahead, but this year uncertainty hangs in the air. Global instability triggered by the Iran war and surging fuel prices have brought unpredictability to the tourism industry, including in Dubrovnik, Croatia's top Adriatic Sea destination that draws millions of visitors annually. The stakes for Croatia's economy are high: The tourism sector is one of the country's key sources of income and is largely dependent on international travellers. Though tourist numbers have been up in Dubrovnik, officials are warning nothing is guaranteed. The UNESCO-protected heritage city is known for its rich medieval history, seafport location and churches and palaces within its stone walls. Dubrovnik's popularity soared after it served as a filming location for the hit TV series "Game of Thrones."

Lavrov, Araghchi discuss Hormuz, Iran nuclear issue

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov held a telephone conversation on Friday with his Iranian counterpart Seyed Abbas Araghchi, focusing on freedom of navigation and developments surrounding Iran's nuclear programme, according to the Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

In a statement, the ministry said the two top diplomats engaged in a detailed exchange of views on the prospects for a full cessation of hostilities and broader efforts to stabilise the military and political situation across the West Asia.

The discussion comes amid heightened regional tensions and increased scrutiny of maritime security, particularly in the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz, a key global energy transit route. Moscow



reiterated its support for ongoing mediation initiatives aimed at de-escalating conflicts in the region. It also expressed readiness to contribute to political and diplomatic efforts designed to achieve sustainable agreements and ensure long-term peace and stability.

The issue of maritime access fea-

tured prominently in the talks.

The ministers addressed the passage of Russian vessels and cargo through the Strait of Hormuz, underlining the importance of maintaining uninterrupted shipping routes amid rising geopolitical uncertainty. The conversation also took place against

the backdrop of recent warnings from the United States to international shipping firms over potential sanctions linked to payments associated with Iranian transit through the waterway, adding further complexity to regional maritime operations.

Both sides emphasised the need for continued dialogue and coordination to prevent further escalation and to safeguard critical international trade routes. The call reflects ongoing diplomatic engagement between Moscow and Tehran as they navigate overlapping strategic interests in the West Asia.

No further details were disclosed regarding specific outcomes of the discussion, but both countries signalled their intent to maintain close communication on regional security and economic concerns.

IRAN HANGS 2 MEN CONVICTED OF SPYING

Beirut: Iran on Saturday said it hanged two men convicted of spying for Israel. The Iranian judiciary's news outlet, Mizanonline, identified the men as Yaghoub Karimpour and Nasser Bekrzadeh. It said they were hanged after the Supreme Court upheld death sentences. The news outlet said Karimpour was accused of sending "sensitive information" to an officer in Israel's Mossad intelligence agency, while Bekrzadeh was alleged to have sent details about government and religious leaders as well as information about Natanz. The central Iranian city is home to a nuclear enrichment facility bombed by Israel and the US last



year.Iran has hanged more than a dozen people over alleged espionage and terrorist activities in recent weeks. Rights groups say Iran routinely holds closed-door trials in which defendants are unable to challenge the accusations they face.

Bangladesh women MPs-elect to take oath on Sunday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The newly elected women Members of Parliament (MPs) will take oath on Sunday, formally assuming their roles in the 13th Parliament from reserved seats.

Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmad, Bir Bikram, is scheduled to administer the oath at 9.00 pm at the Oath Room of the Jatiya Sangsad Bhavan. The information was confirmed on Saturday by Monir Hossain, Director of the Parliament Secretariat, statement read. Earlier, on April 30, the Election Commission issued a gazette notification declaring 49 candidates elected unopposed to the reserved women's seats. Among the elected lawmakers, 36 are from the BNP-led alliance, 12 from the Jamaat-e-Islami-led alliance, and one is an independent candidate.

The BNP-led alliance nominees include Selima Rahman, Shirin Sultana, Rasheda Begum Hira, Rehana Akter



Ranu, Newaz Halima Arly, Farida Yasmin, Bilkis Islam, Shakila Farzana, Helen Jerin Khan, Nilufar Chowdhury Moni, Nipun Roy Chowdhury, Zeeba Amina Khan, Mahmuda Habiba, Sabira Sultana, Sunsila Jabrin, Sanjida Islam (Tulee), Sultana Ahmed, Fahmida Haque, Anna Minz, Subarna Shikdar, Shamim Ara Begum Swapna, Shammi Akter, Ferdousi Ahmed, Bithika Binte Hossain, Suraiya Jerin, Mansura Akter, Jahrat Adib Chowdhury, Momtaz Alo, Fahima Nasrin, Arifa Sultana, Sanjida



A tanker and a car carrier are anchored at sea in the Gulf of Oman near the Strait of Hormuz as seen from the coast near Khor Fakkan, United Arab Emirates

India's new envoy to China arrives in Shanghai

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing/Shanghai

India's new Ambassador to China Vikram Doraiswami arrived in Shanghai on Saturday to take up his posting amid expectations that his appointment will add momentum to the current normalisation process of Sino-India relations.

He was received at the airport by the Indian Consul General in Shanghai Pratik Mathur and other officials.

Doraiswami, a 1992-batch Indian Foreign Service officer, is due to arrive in Beijing on Sunday. In Beijing, the 56-year-old diplomat succeeds Pradeep Kumar Rawat. Before his posting to Beijing, Doraiswami served as India's High Commissioner to the United Kingdom.

His appointment in March this year evoked considerable interest in the Chinese



official media and the Chinese strategic community. Welcoming Doraiswami's appointment, Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesman Lin Jian told a media briefing on March 20 that the new Indian envoy has chosen a Chinese name for himself: Wei Jiameng.

"China welcomes India's new ambassador to China Wei Jiameng, and stands ready to provide every convenience for him to take up

his post in China," Lin said.

According to Chinese scholars, the loose translation of the name in Mandarin is Wei, a common Chinese surname that phonetically matches "Vi" in Vikram. Long ago, Wei was a powerful state during the Warring States period in Chinese history.

Jia means auspicious or praiseworthy, and Meng means alliance, broadly meaning an auspicious or praiseworthy ally, according

to Chinese scholars.

All put together, it can mean "one who forms an excellent alliance", which carries diplomatic significance in the present context of India-China relations, one Chinese scholar said.

Lin said China hopes that after assuming his duties, Doraiswami will make positive contributions to the sustained improvement and development of China-India ties.

India, Nepal draft a roadmap for flood control and irrigation cooperation

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

India and Nepal have drafted a roadmap for collaboration in areas of flood control and irrigation, as senior officials of the two sides met and comprehensively reviewed bilateral water-sector cooperation.

The discussion took place at the two-day 11th meeting of the India-Nepal Joint Committee on Kosi and Gandak Projects, which concluded in Kathmandu. The Indian delegation was led by Santosh Kumar Mall, Principal Secretary, Water Resources Department, Government of Bihar, and the Nepalese delegation was led by Mitra Baral, Director General, Department of Irrigation, according to a press release issued by the Indian Embassy. The meeting com-



prehensively reviewed "India-Nepal cooperation in the Kosi and Gandak projects and drafted a future roadmap for further cooperation, including in the areas of flood control and irrigation," said the Indian Embassy.

During the meeting, the Nepalese delegation agreed to remove encroachments from key Kosi and Gandak

project areas, including canals, barrage zones and embankments to ensure smooth operation and maintenance.

The Indian side agreed to inspect and address drainage and waterlogging issues in the canal command areas of Western Kosi Main Canal and Valmikinagar Gandak Canal on the Nepalese side. (PTI)

Germany focuses on shared interests after US announces troop drawdown

KIRSTEN GRIESHABER/
EMMA BURROWS
■ Berlin

Germany's defence minister on Saturday appeared to take in stride a Pentagon announcement that the United States plans to pull some 5,000 troops out of Germany, saying a drawdown was expected and emphasising the mutual benefit of the longstanding US deployment in Europe.

Boris Pistorius said Europe recognised and was acting on the necessity of doing more to ensure its own security within the US-led NATO military alliance that counts Germany as a key member, and said it is doing so. He suggested America, too, gains from its military deployment in the continent.

"The presence of American soldiers in Europe, and especially in Germany, is in our interest and in the interest of the US," Pistorius told the German news agency dpa.

Pistorius called the move "foreseeable," apparently alluding to President Donald Trump's recent threat of a drawdown in Germany.

Still, the withdrawals planned over the next six to 12 months mark a new deterioration in US relations



with Germany, and European allies more broadly: Trump has expressed exasperation over NATO allies' unwillingness to join his campaign with Israel against Iran, and has lashed out at leaders like German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez and British Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

Merz last week criticised the war in Iran, saying the US is being "humiliated" by the Iranian leadership and calling out Washington's lack of strategy.

Trump meanwhile accused the EU of not complying with its US trade deal and announced plans to increase tariffs next week on cars and trucks produced in the bloc to 25%, a move that would be particularly damaging to Germany, a major automobile manufacturer.

At least one EU lawmaker called the tariff hike "unacceptable" and accused

Trump of breaking yet another US commitment on trade. A pullout of 5,000 soldiers from Germany would amount to about one-seventh of the 36,000 American service members stationed in the country: A sizable, but not critical drawdown. The Pentagon offered few details about which troops or operations would be affected.

More broadly, around 80,000-100,000 US personnel are usually stationed in Europe — depending on operations, exercises and troop rotations.

NATO allies like Germany have expected for over a year that these troops would be the first to leave. Pistorius, in his comments to dpa, said, "We Europeans must take on more responsibility for our security," while stressing recent efforts by Germany to boost its armed forces, accelerate procurement and develop infrastructure. (AP)



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Date: 29.04.2026

Proposals are invited from reputed Institutions/Experienced firms/Companies and Agencies for the purpose of:

"SELECTION OF A CONSULTANT FOR DEVELOPING RECRUITMENT AND STAFF DEVELOPMENT POLICY DOCUMENT".

The detailed Request for Proposal (RFP), including scope of work, eligibility criteria, and terms & conditions, can be downloaded from the official website: <http://osamb.odisha.gov.in> on 30.04.2026. Last date for submission of Proposal 21.05.2026 up to 4 PM.

- The Authority, OSAM Board reserve the right to accept or reject any proposal without assigning any reason.
- Incomplete or late submissions will not be considered.
- Bidders are advised to regularly check the website for updates / corrigendum.

Sd/-

General Manager

OSAM Board, Bhubaneswar

OIPR-39001/39024/1/2627/0001



ODISHA STATE AGRICULTURAL MARKETING BOARD

Plot No. 1800 (P), Baramunda, Post-Khandagiri, Near Indian Oil Petrol Pump Bhubaneswar
Ph. No.0674-2351311, Fax: 0674-2351316, Email: osamboard99@yahoo.com, Website: osamboard.org

39001/18/2627

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL

Estt II- 03 / 2026

Date: 29.04.2026

Proposals are invited from reputed Institutions/Experienced firms/Companies and Agencies for the purpose of:

"SELECTION OF A CONSULTANT FOR SETTING UP PROJECT MANAGEMENT UNIT (PMU)".

The detailed Request for Proposal (RFP), including scope of work, eligibility criteria, and terms & conditions, can be downloaded from the official website: <http://osamb.odisha.gov.in> on 30.05.2026. Last date for submission of Proposal 21.05.2026 up to 4 PM.

- The Authority, OSAM Board reserve the right to accept or reject any proposal without assigning any reason.
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Sd/-

General Manager

OSAM Board, Bhubaneswar

OIPR-39001/39024/1/2627/0002

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Sushil Kumar to inform to the public at large that Mr. Sushil Kumar is the owner of the M.I.G. Flat No.1615, First Floor, Without Roof Rights, measuring 34.82 Sq. Meters, Situated at Vasundhara, Sector-16, Ghaziabad U.P. who owned the said Property through Sale Deed dated 10/12/2018. (Doc. No.27148) and same to be mortgage from Cholamandalam Investment and Finance Company Ltd. That, (1) Original Allotment Letter & (2) Original Possession Letter in favour of Smt. Bhagirathi Devi, (3) Original W.L.L. dated 27/01/1987 (Doc. No.153) in favour of Sh. Raju Arya and Sh. Bishan Ram Arya, (4) Death Certificate dated 31/01/2007 & (5) Surviving Member Certificate of Late Smt. Bhagirathi Devi, (6) Original Mutation Letter in the name of Sh. Raju Arya and Sh. Bishan Ram Arya, (7) Original Sale Deed dated 23/04/2003 (Doc. No.11173) in favour of Sh. Raju Arya and Sh. Bishan Ram Arya are lost. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all types of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP B-33B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2, Noida. UP-201301Contact90120-4269373

Public Notice

I, Bhal Singh S/o Amar Singh is owner in respect of property i.e. Plot No. 125, LGD, 1st 60440125 AT ULD No. No.604440W/PAS100R0125A, measuring area 140.441 Sq. Mtrs, situated in Lal Dors of village Khara Khari, Tehsil Fatehabad, District Fatehabad as per Certification Deed No.5887 dated 29.08.2023. Smt. Gini Rin Limited Have lost Certification Deed No.5887 dated 29.08.2023 anywhere in Gurugram. A DOR No. 132770620620045 also registered at Gurugram. I also declare that I have not taken any type of Loan, CC Limit or OD Limit on the said property. If anybody found and any concern with in this property, please contact. Advocate Bhupander Kumar, Ph. no. 828949981 # 1591, SECTOR 16-17, HISAR WITHIN 7 DAY OF THIS PUBLICATION

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that my client MR. RITESH DEBROY, son of Mr. Ranendra Debroy, resident of B-387 Sarita Vihar New Delhi-110076 has lost/ misplaced the Original DDA issued Demand-cum-Allotment Letter, Allocation Letter, Possession Slip, NOC for Water and Electricity in the name of the original allottee in respect of Dr. Dima SCS (FAT No. B-387 SARITA VIHAR NEW DELHI 110076, and are not traceable. An NCR/FR has been lodged with the local police vide LR No. 271796/2026 dated 01/05/2026. Any person claiming any right, title, interest, having any objection or found in possession of original document, may write/contact Dr. Director (LAB/ SFS) H or Director (H-1), Vikas Sadan, JNA, New Delhi and also to the named persons at above address/phone no. 8447894401, within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

ACHIN SHARMA (ADVOCATE)

(Regd. No. D5425/2021); G-2/210, Tulsī Tower, Alakanda Shopping Comp. New Delhi-110019



OFFICE OF THE PROJECT MANAGER, CONSTRUCTION UNIT,
UTTARAKHAND PEYJAL NIGAM
NEAR HAUMAN MANDIR PITHORAGARH, DISTRICT- PITHORAGARH 262501

Letter no. 556/Nivida/50

Dated: 28-04-2026

E-Tender Notice

1. Name of the work:- CONSTRUCTION OF BOXING RING AT K.N.U.G.I.C. PITHORAGARH, DISTRICT - PITHORAGARH.

2. Estimated Cost:- Rs. 55.36 Lakh

3. Period of Completion:- 15 Month

4. Date and Time of availability of Bid documents in the portal: 29-04-2026 (17.00 hrs)

5. Online Bid submission: End date :- 19-05-2026 (17.00 hrs)

6. Date & Time of bid Opening:- 23-05-2026 (13.00 hrs)

7. Name and Address of the Officer inviting bid:- Project Manager, Construction Unit, Uttarakhand Pey Jal Nigam, Pithoragarh.

8. Pre-bid meeting details (if required) Date & Place :- 02-05-2026 (11.00 hrs) Project Manager, Construction Unit, Uttarakhand Pey Jal Nigam, Pithoragarh.

9. For further details, details of subsequent Amendment / correction documentation etc. may be obtained from the e-Procurement portal www.uktenders.gov.in

PROJECT MANAGER



AXIS BANK LTD.

IN CASE OF ANY QUERIES, WRITE TO US AT - AXIS BANK LTD., AXIS HOUSE, TOWER F-2, 2ND FLOOR, I-14, SECTOR-128, NOIDA EXPRESSWAY, JAYPEE GREENS WISHTOWN, NOIDA (U.P.)-201301.

REGISTERED OFFICE: "TRISHUL" - 3RD FLOOR OPP. SAMARTHESWAR TEMPLE, NEAR LAW GARDEN, ELLISBRIDGE, AHMEDABAD - 380006. TELEPHONE NO. 079-26409322 FAX NO. - 079-26409321 CIN: L65110GJ1993PLC020769 WEBSITE - WWW.AXISBANK.COM

APPENDIX IV (REFER RULE - 8(1)) POSSESSION NOTICE (FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY)

Whereas the undersigned being the authorized officer of Axis Bank Ltd. Under the securitisation and reconstruction of financial assets and enforcement of security interest act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with rule 3 of the security interest (enforcement) rules, 2002 issued Demand notice dated 11-dec-2025 calling Sh. Kaushal kumar & Ms. Soni kumari to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.41,37,211/- (Rupees forty one lakhs thirty seven thousand two hundred and eleven only) against as on 08-dec-2025 and interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower(s)/co-borrower(s)/mortgagor(s)/guarantor(s) above said having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower(s)/co-borrower(s)/mortgagor(s)/guarantor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under section 13 (4) of the said act read with rule 8 of security interest (enforcement) rules, 2002 on 08-dec-2025 and interest and cost thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.

The borrower(s)/co-borrower(s)/mortgagor(s)/guarantor(s) above said in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the properties and any dealings with the properties will be subject to the charge of the Axis Bank Ltd. For an amount of Rs. 41,37,211/- (Rupees forty one lakhs thirty seven thousand two hundred and eleven only) as on 08-dec-2025 together with further interest thereon at the contractual rate of interest till the date of payment & expenses thereon.

The borrower(s)/co-borrower(s)/mortgagor(s)/guarantor(s)'s attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY ALL THAT PART AND PARCEL OF PROPERTY BEARING: All Piece & Parcels Flat Unit Nos. C-2405, 23rd Floor, Tower C, Plot Nos.dv-GH-09c, Jm Florence, Techzone Iv, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh.

Please note that as mention in sub section 13 of section 13 of the aforesaid act, you shall not transfer by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of the assets stated under security referred to in this notice without prior written consent of our bank.

Dated: 03-05-2026, Place: GREATER NOIDA Sd/-, Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.



Israeli strikes kill 7 in Lebanon amid ceasefire

BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon killed at least seven people and wounded others on Saturday as hostilities continued between Israel and Hezbollah despite a ceasefire.

The Israeli airstrikes on southern Lebanon Saturday came as Israel's military issued a new warning for residents of nine southern villages to evacuate.

Israel's military and Lebanon's Hezbollah have kept up their attacks despite a ceasefire in place since April 17. Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported an airstrike on a car in the village of Kfar Dajal that killed two people, while another hit a home in the village of Lwaizeh killing three. NNA also reported a strike on the village of Shoukin that killed two people.

Israel's military Arabic-language



Sanaa Khalil a Syrian farmer who lost her legs in an Israeli airstrike in Lebanon

AP

spokeswoman, Lt Col Ella Waweya, posted on X that the Israeli air force carried out about 50 airstrikes over

the past 24 hours, saying that they targeted Hezbollah infrastructure and members. Hezbollah said that

it attacked on Saturday Israeli troops who gathered inside a house in the coastal village of Bayed with a drone. The latest war between Israel and Hezbollah began on March 2, when Hezbollah fired rockets into northern Israel two days after the United States and Israel launched a war on its main backer, Iran.

Israel has since carried out hundreds of airstrikes and launched a ground invasion of southern Lebanon, capturing dozens of towns and villages along the border.

Since then Lebanon and Israel have held their first direct talks in more than three decades. The two countries have formally been in a state of war since the founding of the state of Israel in 1948.

A 10-day ceasefire declared in Washington went into effect on April 17. The ceasefire was later extended by three weeks. (AP)

Pakistan police arrest 21 terrorists in Punjab province



M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Twenty-one terrorists, mostly affiliated with the banned TTP outfit, were arrested in Pakistan's Punjab province during the past week, police said on Saturday.

The Counter Terrorism Department (CTD) of Punjab Police, in a statement, said it conducted more than 200 intelligence-based operations across the province and apprehended 21 terrorists.

Most of the apprehended terrorists were linked to the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), it said.

"A dangerous TTP terrorist, Pir Shams, was arrested from Lahore, while Abdul Latif of the BLA was apprehended from Toba Tek Singh along with explosive material," the statement said.

According to the CTD, 6,330 grams of explosives, 17 detonators, 39 feet of safety fuse wire, one improvised explosive device were recovered from them. "The arrested terrorists were planning attacks at various locations," the statement said. (PTI)

Russian drone hits Ukrainian minibus, 2 dead

SAMYA KULLAB ■ Kyiv

Two people were killed after a Russian drone attacked a minibus in the southern Ukrainian city of Kherson, local officials said Saturday, in the latest barrage of civilian areas, a hallmark of Moscow's full-scale invasion of its neighbour.

Seven people were also wounded in the attack, regional head Oleksandr Prokudin said. Hours later Russia attacked another minibus in Kherson, wounding the driver, he said.

On Ukraine's Black Sea coast, a Russian strike damaged port infrastructure in the city of Odesa. No

casualties were reported.

Ukrainian civilians have endured relentless air assaults since Russia launched a full-scale invasion of its neighbour more than four years ago.

US-brokered talks between Moscow and Kyiv over the past year have brought no respite, with Russia rejecting Ukraine's offer of a ceasefire, and in recent weeks the Iran war has diverted international attention from Ukraine's plight.

Meanwhile, on the roughly 1,250-km (750-mile) front line, Russia claimed Saturday it had taken control of the village of Myropillia in Ukraine's northeastern Sumy region. It was not pos-



Vantor showing smoke rising from oil infrastructure in Tuapse

AP

sible to independently verify the battlefield claims, and Ukraine did not immediately comment.

In Russia, local officials in the Krasnodar region said that a fire that broke out Friday following a Ukrainian strike on an oil terminal in

the Black Sea city of Tuapse was put out on Saturday.

Drones have hit the oil refinery and export terminal in Tuapse on four occasions in just over two weeks, sparking fires that prompted local evacuations and sent up massive plumes of smoke. (AP)

Taiwan's president lands in Eswatini despite curbs

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Taipei



Taiwan's President Lai Ching-te said he arrived in the African nation of Eswatini on Saturday, days after his Government was forced to push back the trip when several countries withdrew permission for him to fly over their territories reportedly over Chinese pressure.

In a post on X, Lai said he arrived in Eswatini - Taiwan's only diplomatic ally in Africa — to "affirm our longstanding friendship". He said that Taiwan, a self-ruled democracy that China considers part

of its territory, "will never be deterred by external pressures".

Lai was originally scheduled to visit the southern African country from April 22, but Taiwanese officials said flight permits were revoked by Seychelles, Mauritius and Madagascar over "strong pressure from the Chinese authorities, including economic coercion".

Bangladesh PM paves way for flood protection infra in Sylhet

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dhaka

Prime Minister Tarique Rahman on Saturday initiated a riverfront development project along the Surma River in Bangladesh's Sylhet district, according to a media report.

The project focuses on constructing flood protection infrastructure and improving the river banks through beautification measures, state-owned news agency Bangladesh Sangbad Sangsthan (BSS) reported.

The project is part of wider efforts by the government to strengthen urban infrastruc-



ture in riverine areas, and it aims to mitigate the catastrophic damage caused by floods, especially during the monsoons, in the Ganga-Brahmaputra delta region.

According to a 2024 UNICEF report, flash floods in Sylhet division affected more than 2 million people. Over

Starmer urges tougher action against Gaza protests in UK

SYLVIA HUI ■ London

UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer warned Saturday that tougher action was needed against people chanting certain phrases at pro-Palestinian protests, as concerns grew over the safety of British Jews after the stabbings of two Jewish men in London.

Starmer said he would always defend the right to protest, but said there may be instances where some marches protesting the war in Gaza should be banned.

He suggested that repeated pro-Palestinian marches have had a "cumulative effect" linked to the rise in antisemitic incidents in the UK.

"When you see, when you hear some of those chants — globalise the intifada' would be one I would pick out — then clearly there should be tougher action in relation to that," Starmer told the BBC. The Arabic word intifada is generally translated as "uprising." (AP)



Spirit Airlines shuts down after 34 years, ends operations



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ West Palm Beach

Spirit Airlines, an impish upstart that shook the industry with its irreverent ads and deep discount fares, announced on Saturday that it has gone out of business after 34 years. The ultra-low cost airline that once operated hundreds of daily flights on its bright yellow planes and employed about 17,000 people said it had "started an orderly wind-down of our operations, effective immediately."

The airline said on its website that all flights have been cancelled and customer service is no longer available. "We are proud of the impact of our ultra-low-cost model on the industry over the last 34 years and had hoped to serve our guests for many years to come," the announcement said. The company advised customers that they could

expect refunds but there would be no help in booking travel on other airlines. The shutdown was expected after Friday came and went without a needed government bailout for the cash-strapped business.

President Donald Trump said on Friday that his administration had given the budget carrier a "final proposal" for a taxpayer-funded takeover to keep it from going under, but a deal was not reached.

Trump floated the idea of a bailout last week after the airline found itself in bankruptcy proceedings for the second time in less than two years with jet fuel prices soaring because of the Iran war. About 17,000 jobs could be impacted by a shutdown, Spirit lawyer Marshall Huebner said. Spirit has struggled financially since the COVID-19 pandemic, weighed down by rising operating costs.

Ghana rejects US health deal over data-sharing concerns



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Accra

Ghana has rejected a proposed health deal with the US over provisions that would have allowed US entities access to the nation's sensitive health data without necessary safeguards, an official said. It was the latest African country to walk away from the deal over similar concerns. Arnold Kavaarpuo, executive director of Ghana's Data Protection Commission, said the scope of data access requested "went far beyond what would typically be

required for the purpose for which it's stated." The US State Department did not immediately respond to AP's inquiry about the Ghanaian official's comments. The US has struck such health deals with nearly two dozen African nations under the Trump administration's "America First" approach to global health funding.

The new approach that kicked off late last year replaces a patchwork of previous health agreements under the now-dismantled United States Agency for International Development.

Nepal razes 2,000 illegal buildings in massive Kathmandu drive

SHIRISH B PRAHDAN ■ Kathmandu

Continuing its demolition drive, the Nepal government on Saturday razed hundreds of illegal structures along riverbanks in parts of Kathmandu Valley, while the opposition urged the authorities to be sensitive to the affected people.

So far, 2,000 squatter settlements, including concrete buildings, built on riverbanks, public and government land have been demolished. The demolition of illegal structures was carried out in Swoyambhu, Balaju and Dhovikhola areas of Kathmandu. Thousands of



security personnel were deployed for the drive.

On Friday, illegal structures built at Teku and Balkhu were demolished while last week, the authorities bulldozed structures at Thapathali, Gairigaun and

Manohara areas of the capital. The government has come under severe criticism from the opposition for not showing sensitivity and giving adequate time for the landless squatters to remove their belongings.

Parliament member and Nepali Congress leader Arjun Narsingh KC said although the government campaign was necessary for the beautification of the urban areas and environment protection, its implementation has come under scrutiny from a humanitarian, legal and social perspective.

"The biggest question is displacement without alternatives," he said. (PTI)

Madame Tussauds launches 'Icons of India' celebration in London

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Madame Tussauds launched a new "Icons of India" celebration at its London headquarters this week, uniting the wax models of celebrities from the world of cinema and cricket.

The limited-time experience includes 13 figures of leading Indian actors and cricketers within the leading British tourist attraction's special Awards Party zone.

For the month of May and June, the area has been transformed into a vibrant space inspired by Indian culture for visitors to get up close with some of the most its iconic wax figures including Amitabh Bachchan and Sachin Tendulkar.

"Bollywood's global appeal is huge, and London's love for Indian cinema and cricket grows stronger every year," said Steve Blackburn, General Manager at Madame Tussauds London.

"With 'Icons of India', we are bringing fans closer than ever to the stars they love. We are thrilled to invite guests to step into this world of magic, capture unforgettable moments, and celebrate the icons who have shaped global entertainment and sport," he said.

Describing it as a "truly global celebration", some of the wax figures have made their journey to London on loan from other Madame Tussauds attractions, including Virat Kohli from Bangkok and



Aishwarya Rai from New York. The 'Icons of India' exhibit has been created to allow fans to strike a pose with their favourites, from Deepika Padukone and Ranveer Singh to Priyanka Chopra Jonas, Hrithik Roshan, Katrina Kaif and Madhuri Dixit.

The models of Ranbir

Kapoor and Telugu cinema star Kajal Aggarwal have travelled from Madame Tussauds in New York and Singapore.

The High Commission of India in London backed the exhibition as a "vibrant celebration of the shared cultural affinity between our two nations". "Showcasing the

global appeal of Indian cinema and cricket, this initiative brings the spirit of India to the heart of London while strengthening people-to-people ties, which stand as a testament to the enduring cultural bridge between India and the United Kingdom," it stated.

Madame Tussauds in London dates back nearly 200 years and has since expanded to 24 locations around the world, including New York, Shanghai, Amsterdam and Sydney.

It employs a combination of historic artistic methods, immersive sets and modern technology to create several lifelike figures from the worlds of royalty, cinema, sports, politics and more. (PTI)

Zubeen's death: Legal experts debate vessel operator liability

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

The drowning of Indian singer-composer Zubeen Garg has brought the spotlight on rules and regulations that concern responsibilities of vessel operators when dealing with intoxicated passengers, according to a media report that cited legal experts.

A cultural icon in India's northeastern region, 52-year-old Garg travelled to Singapore in September 2025 to perform at a live event. A day before his performance, he went on a yacht trip with a group of people. He drowned while swimming in the sea near Lazarus Island, which is a popular diving spot. His death shook his home state



Assam, where millions came out on the streets mourning. Later, police cases were registered against the organiser of the event, his manager and some others.

Nico Lee, managing director of the Triangle Legal law

firm, told The Straits Times that Singapore has Maritime and Port Authority of Singapore (Port) Regulations under which there are provisions to debar drunk passengers. The owner, agent or captain of the vessel must

not allow persons under the influence of alcohol or drugs onboard if they are intoxicated to a point where they endanger safety of the vessel, its crew or any person in it.

"In terms of civil liability, it could be argued that a yacht captain is negligent, as he owes a prima facie duty of care to guests on board under general negligence principles," Lee was quoted as saying by the newspaper. The singer and his entourage of about 15 individuals were partying on a chartered vessel, which they had boarded at Marina at Keppel Bay.

A death certificate issued by the Singapore General Hospital listed his cause of death as drowning. An autopsy report suggested

that Garg had 333 mg of alcohol per 100 ml of blood in his system, which was four times the legal limit for driving in Singapore and is likely to have impacted his coordination.

Citing Garg's case, Lee said the circumstances were serious, as the controller of the vessel knew that the guest was intoxicated. Also, he may not have understood or processed a safety briefing for all passengers.

"That combination makes reliance on an ordinary briefing inadequate. If intoxication reaches a level that endangers the safety of the vessel or persons on board, the person in charge should not permit boarding at all," he said. (PTI)

Pope Leo encourages wealthy US Catholics to keep donating

NICOLE WINFIELD ■ Rome

Pope Leo XIV on Saturday encouraged some of the wealthiest US Catholics to keep on giving to support his charitable works, in an audience that confirmed how the election of the first US-born pope has invigorated American Catholics and their donations.

The Chicago-born Leo met with members of The Papal Foundation, a major funder of papal development projects in the developing world, in the Apostolic Palace at the end of their annual pilgrimage to Rome. In his remarks, Leo thanked the foundation stew-



ards for their generosity, which he said had allowed "countless people to experience in a concrete fashion the goodness and kindness of God in their own communities".

He noted in particular the priests and nuns from poor

countries who are able to study at Rome's pontifical universities to earn advanced degrees thanks to scholarships funded by foundation's grants, which combined over the past four decades have more than \$270 million.

While The Papal Foundation contributions to the Vatican remained strong during Pope Francis' 12-year pontificate. Some US Catholics also soured on donating to the Holy See following years of unrelenting stories of mismanagement, corruption and scandal, as well as Francis' known criticism of American-style Capitalism. (AP)



India select Yastika, uncapped Nandini for women's T20 WC

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India on Saturday drafted in uncapped Nandini Sharma and wicketkeeper batter Yastika Bhatia in the 15-player squad for the upcoming Women's T20 World Cup, beginning June 12 in England and Wales.

While specialist batters Pratika Rawal and Harleen Deol were excluded, all-rounder Amanjot Kaur and Kashvee Gautam missed out on selection owing to injuries.

Harmanpreet Kaur will lead all the squads with Smriti Mandhana being her deputy.

Pratika, however, has been named in the squad for the one-off Test against England to be played at the Lord's between July 10 and 13 whereas Harleen will lead the India A side in the ODI series. Medium pacer Nandini was handed her maiden India call-up after doing well in WPL, where she played 10 matches for Delhi Capitals, taking 17 wickets.

She was also part of the India squad that played in the Women's Asia Cup Rising Stars tournament in Bangkok in February this year.

The fast bowling line-up also does not feature Pooja Vastrakar. Renuka Singh Thakur will continue to lead the pace attack with Arundhati Reddy and Kranti Goud in tow.

There was no place for Anushka Sharma and Uma Chetry, who had toured South Africa.

The core squad is similar to the one which won the ODI Women's World Cup in November last year.

Mandhana, Shafali Verma and Jemimah Rodrigues are expected to form the top three while the inclusion of Bharti Fulmali, who did an

impressive job lower down the order in the Women's Premier League, will complete the batting line-up along with other finishers such as Richa Ghosh and Deepti Sharma.

Deepti will be at the helm of the spin bowling attack which also has Shreyanka Patil, Shree Charani and Radha Yadav, who has not played for India since the England tour last year.

However, the team's think tank will be forced to work hard to fill the void created by the absence of Amanjot has been ruled out of action for 4-5 months due to a back injury.

The squad picked for World Cup will also compete in the preceding three-match T20I series against hosts England, starting May 28.

India will open their campaign with a game against against Pakistan on June 14 in Birmingham. The final is scheduled for July 5 at Lord's. India have never won T20 World title.

India squad for England T20Is and T20 World Cup: Harmanpreet Kaur (c), Smriti Mandhana (vc), Shafali Verma, Jemimah Rodrigues, Bharti Fulmali, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh (wk), Sree Charani, Yastika Bhatia (2nd wk), Nandini Sharma, Arundhati Reddy, Renuka Thakur, Kranti Gaud, Shreyanka Patil, Radha Yadav.

England: Harmanpreet Kaur (c), Smriti Mandhana (vc), Shafali Verma, Jemimah Rodrigues, Pratika Rawal, Richa Ghosh, Sree Charani, Yastika Bhatia, Nandini Sharma, Harleen Deol, Renuka Singh, Kranti Gaud, Sayali Satghare, Sneha Rana.

Norris wins pole for the Miami Grand Prix

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Miami Gardens

Reigning Formula 1 champion Lando Norris won the pole for Saturday's sprint race at the Miami Grand Prix, beating current F1 points leader Kimi Antonelli of Mercedes. Norris' McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri was third, only 0.017 seconds behind Antonelli, ahead of the second sprint race of the season.

Friday was the first time drivers were able to test changes made by FIA, the sports governing body — during a five-week hiatus. The organisation implemented changes to the regulations after drivers heavily criticized how the electrical battery power has changed the cars and competition.

"It was great," Norris said. "Perfect result for us, nice way to reward the team."

We've got a lot of new upgrades on the car, so nice to feel some grip again.... I've always loved Miami."

Charles Leclerc of Ferrari finished fourth, ahead of Red Bull's Max Verstappen.

Sergio Perez and Valtteri Bottas qualified 19th and 20th, respectively, in Cadillac's debut on North American soil.

Max still thinking about his future Max Verstappen has "nothing new" to say regarding his future racing plans and whether the four-time world champion is seriously considering quitting Formula 1.

The Dutchman first suggested he could walk away after the Japanese Grand Prix in March. He's been vocal about his dissatisfaction with new regulations and called changes made to the cars ahead of this weekend's Miami Grand Prix "a tickle" of a fix.



He said in Miami he has not considered his future because he's been "busy with other things," which included racing at the Nordschleife in Germany to prepare for a 24-hour

race later in May.

"I still have time and I'm taking my time," he said. "The rest, I mean, also for myself, I don't know at the moment. What I said in Japan is still the same, but I

We hear Indian athletes running away when there's doping control: ITA head

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New York

The head of the International Testing Agency (ITA), the body that manages anti-doping programme in Olympic Games and other major global events, has expressed concern at the high rate of doping cases in India and athletes getting "advance notice prior to testing" and avoiding furnishing samples if there is doping control.

ITA Director General Benjamin Cohen said in a report that the International Olympic Committee (IOC) has passed on the message that if India wants to host the 2036 Games, the country needs to undergo "a lot of governance and structural reforms".

"We're concerned in general with the state of doping in India and we're hearing a lot of things happening on the ground," Cohen was quoted as saying by 'The Athletic', which covers sports for 'The New York Times'.

"We also hear stories of athletes running away when there is a doping control, and we hear of advance notice (given to athletes prior to testing)."

Besides overseeing anti-doping tests on behalf of the IOC, the Lausanne-based ITA also manages the anti-doping programme of around 50 international sports federations.

Cohen said he met with the officials of the New Delhi-based National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) and Indian Olympic Association (IOA) at the recent Winter Olympics in Milano Cortina in Italy, and he was warmed by their apparent willingness to "team up with the ITA".

But, he also admitted that getting India to join forces with ITA won't be an easy task as that could be perceived (by India) as an admission of failure of its (anti-doping) system.



"I'm going to be frank: there is still some resistance to engage with the ITA, as there can be a perception in India that this is almost an admission of failure of the system, or that they're not going to be seen as competent enough to deal with their own problems, so they have to join forces with an independent international organisation."

"There's a bit of scepticism as to how it's going to be perceived in the Indian community. But I think they (India) are on the right track in that it is now known that the IOA and the Ministry of Sports want to do something: they want to invest. They have the resources, so I think it's just a matter of time," he said.

The ITA works with an increasing number of National Anti-Doping Organisations (NADOs) around the world to exchange intelligence and information, coordinate testing plans, and collaborate on specific cases or areas such as sample collection and education.

India has been topping the World Anti-Doping Agency's (WADA) list of dope offenders for three consecutive years with the highest positivity rate among major nations.

The country is scheduled to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games in Ahmedabad and is aspiring to become an Olympic host in 2036 in the Gujarat capital.

Doha, the capital of Qatar, is also in the running to host the 2036 Olympics, and the host city for that edition is expected to be known before 2028 Games in Los Angeles.

Last month, WADA President Witold Banka said at the sidelines of a conference on Global Anti-Doping Intelligence and Investigations Network (GAIIN) held in New Delhi that "nobody is blind" to India's serious doping problem but acknowledged that there have been "sincere efforts" to address it.

He had also said India is the biggest producer of Performance Enhancing Drug (PEDs) and steroids in the world.

also still have a lot of time."

Miami is the first race in five weeks because two Middle East events were called off due to the war in Iran. During that time, Verstappen's race engineer Gianpiero Lambiase said he is leaving for McLaren by 2028 at the latest. The duo has been together since 2016.

Verstappen had previously claimed he would not want to work with another race engineer, but has backedtracked on that now.

"Otherwise I don't get to drive, I will have to work with someone else," added Verstappen. "But I think times change and the offer that he got, I would be an idiot to try and keep him. It's not only about me all the time, it's also about his career and moving forward. So for me, it was a no-brainer to be honest. But the future, that's what we're looking at now

with a different race engineer. I'm sure we'll find a solution for that as well."

American born: Colton Herta is not the only American in the junior F2 series racing at Miami this weekend — also in the field is Sebastian Montoya, who was born and raised in this city before moving to Europe to pursue his racing career.

The 21-year-old is the son of former F1 driver Juan Pablo Montoya. He races under the Colombian flag, but has American citizenship by birthright.

He is thrilled to be racing in his former hometown.

"It's really emotional because I grew up here. I think the first time I drove a go-kart was 15 minutes away," Montoya said. "So to see how far it's actually come is amazing and obviously I dreamed of hopefully one day racing here in FL."



Alex Zanardi dies at 59 after life-altering accidents

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Alex Zanardi, the Italian auto racing champion-turned-Paralympic gold medalist whose career was marked by two life-altering accidents, has died. He was 59.

Zanardi's family announced his death on Saturday, saying that he passed away on Friday night. "Alex died peacefully, surrounded by the affection of those closest to him," the family said in a statement without providing a cause of death.

In 2020, Zanardi was seriously injured in a handbike accident after crashing into an oncoming truck during a relay event in Tuscany. Zanardi suffered serious facial and cranial trauma in the crash and was put in a medically induced coma.

Nearly 20 years earlier, Zanardi lost both of his legs in an auto racing crash.

"Italy loses a great champion and an extraordinary man, capable of turning every challenge of life into a lesson in courage,

strength, and dignity," Italian Premier Giorgia Meloni said on X.

"Alex Zanardi knew how to bounce back every time, facing even the toughest challenges with determination, clarity, and a strength of spirit that was truly exceptional," Meloni added. "With his sporting achievements, with his example, and with his humanity, he gave all of us much more than a victory: he gave hope, pride, and the strength to never give up. On behalf of myself and the government, I extend my heartfelt thoughts and the sincerest closeness to his family and to all those who loved him. Thank you for everything, Alex."

Zanardi won two championships in CART — 1997 and 1998 — in the United States before a brief move to Formula One. He returned to America and was racing in Germany in a CART event in 2001 when both of his legs were severed in a horrific accident the weekend after the Sept.

India to miss Lakshya Sen in Thomas Cup semifinal vs France due to swollen elbow

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Horsens (Denmark)

A swollen right elbow has ruled out Lakshya Sen from India's Thomas Cup semifinal clash against France on Saturday night and world No. 30 Kidambi Shrikant will compete in his absence.

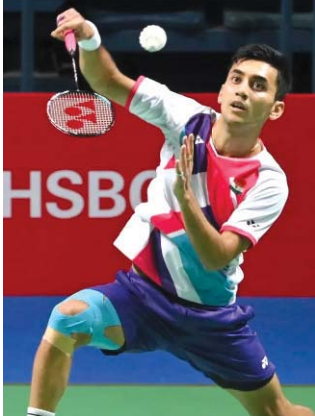
The 24-year-old Lakshya had saved two match points to script an 18-21 22-20 21-17 victory over world No. 6 Chou Tien Chen in a marathon clash lasting one hour and 28 minutes, helping India notch up a commanding 3-0 win over Chinese Taipei in the quarterfinals on Friday.

However, the Commonwealth Games champion hurt his elbow

while diving for a shot during an intense rally.

"Lakshya sustained an impact to his elbow following an intense quarterfinal match that involved multiple dives. Following a thorough evaluation by the team's medical staff, the decision has been taken as a precautionary measure to allow Lakshya adequate recovery time and ensure he is in optimal condition for the final, should India progress," Badminton Association of India (BAI) General Secretary Sanjay Mishra said in a statement.

"He is currently under close medical observation and receiving all necessary support. The team remains confident and



optimistic about his swift recovery and return to peak form."

"Lakshya is also struggling with blisters on his feet," former

India coach and his mentor Vimal Kumar told PTI.

With Lakshya unavailable, young Ayush Shetty will play the opening singles against world No. 4 Christo Popov, who had defeated the Indian in their only meeting at the Hylo Open in 2024.

Srikanth, who had won six matches during India's title run in 2022, will feature in the second singles against world No. 10 Alex Lanier.

HS Prannoy, who has delivered as a third singles player, will then take on world No. 17 Toma Junior Popov, who has a 1-0 head-to-head record against the Indian, having beaten him at the All England Championships in 2025.

Mallorca wins at Girona as La Liga relegation fight tightens

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Girona (Spain)

A first half goal from Samu Costa was enough to give Mallorca a 1-0 win at Girona and further tighten the already wicked relegation fight in La Liga.

Mallorca's first away win on Friday since October lifted it above Girona on goal difference into 15th place in the 20-team table. Both clubs were four points clear of the relegation zone.

Only six points separate Rayo Vallecano in 11th with second-from-bottom Levante.

Mallorca was on top for much of the opening 45 minutes and it got its reward seconds before halftime. Costa was unmarked in the box and he stole in to head home Johan Mojica's lofted cross from the left. Girona pushed harder in the



second half but the woodwork and goalkeeper Leo Roman saved Mallorca. Veteran striker Cristhian Stuani acknowledged the defeat was a hard one to take.

"It's getting more difficult," Stuani said. "We have to grit our teeth and give it everything."

Leeds takes big step toward Premier League survival with comfy win over Burnley

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Leeds (England)

Leeds United took a massive step towards confirming its Premier League status after a comfortable 3-1 victory over Burnley.

The win on Friday almost certainly guarantees top tier football at Elland Road next season. Leeds moved nine points clear of Tottenham Hotspur, the team occupying the third and last relegation spot.

Daniel Farke's men improved to 14th place, above Newcastle, Nottingham Forest and West Ham, all of whom have a game in hand. The bottom two, Wolves and Burnley, are

already going down. The Leeds players celebrated in front of a delirious home crowd at the final whistle and although they were not taking their survival for granted yet the win was clearly a relief.

"It's an unbelievable feeling," one of Leeds' stars Dominic Calvert-Lewin said. "Leading from the front, high up the pitch, and we executed the game plan really well. They've come in playing with nothing to lose and that can be dangerous sometimes, but pleased with and proud of the boys with how we've performed."

Anton Stach put the home side ahead in the eighth minute with a low shot from



30 meters out that somehow sneaked inside Martin Dubravka's post.

The second came seven minutes into the second half thanks to sloppy defending by Burnley's Bashir Humphreys. His pass was intercepted by Calvert-Lewin, whose neat back-heel created more space in the Burnley defense and allowed Noah Okafor to fire home.

Calvert-Lewin got the third himself four minutes later when he was on hand to prod home in a crowded penalty box after Dubravka could only parry Ao Tanaka's long-range effort.

Loum Tchaouna got Burnley's consolation goal.

The Lancashire club fired manager Scott Parker after two years in the role on Thursday and interim coach Mike Jackson was appointed for the last four games of the season.

"I knew this game could go one of two ways with what's happened in the last 24 hours," Jackson said.

"The shock of it to the group. I had a feeling it could go a little bit like that. First half, first 25 minutes, we looked a little bit shell-shocked in a way. We grew into the game a little bit more. We started the second half I thought pretty well, and then we can't make those errors. And then you're always up against it."

Pisa, Verona relegated by Lecce win while Venezia promoted

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Pisa (Italy)

Lecce beat Pisa 2-1 and sent the Tuscan club into the Italian second division.

Pisa was promoted from Serie B a year ago but goes down after a woeful season in Serie A in which it won only two of its 35 games so far.

The result on Friday also meant relegation for second-from-bottom Verona. It has 19 points, one more than Pisa, but it cannot catch Lecce, which is fourth-to-last in the table with



32. Lameck Banda put Pisa 1-0 up in the 52nd minute but Mehdi Leris equalized for the home side four minutes later.

However, Walid Cheddira scored a 65th-minute winner for visiting Lecce to lift it four points above the relegation zone with three matches left to play.

Serie B's Venezia also got the point it needed to secure promotion thanks to a 2-2 draw with Spezia.

Giovanni Stroppa's team tops the Serie B table, one point ahead of Frosinone, which can join Venezia in the top tier with a win or draw against Mantova in its final match next Friday.



Don't need to answer critics: Riyan Parag

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

He may have copped criticism for various reasons of late, but Rajasthan Royals skipper Riyan Parag, who returned to form with a sparkling 90, said he does not need to “answer his critics” but his job is to win matches for his team.

Parag’s 50-ball 90 and Donovan Ferreira’s brutal 14-ball 47 not out powered RR to 225/6, but they fell short, losing to Delhi Capitals by seven wickets in their IPL match here on Friday.

“I don’t think I need to answer any critics or anyone talking about it (vaping). But at the end of the day, my job

is to get two points. So, my score and my innings don’t really matter if we lose the game,” said Parag at the post-match presentation.

Before this knock, Parag had scored 117 runs from nine innings, with his previous best being 29.

If his woeful run with the bat was not enough, he was also caught on camera vaping inside the dugout and was handed a fine of 25 percent of his match fee.

His decision to bat first on a sluggish pitch baffled many, but Parag said they lost the match because of their poor middle-overs bowling.

“I think it was a good score. I thought 200 was a par score here. It was going



to slow down a bit, but I think we could have bowled way better in the middle overs, not let them get away a little too much.

“And then a lot of boundaries in one single over and that repeated. So, I felt we

missed the trick with that, but no harm with the decision we made,” he added.

The RR skipper also had an injury setback and stayed off the field after pulling a hamstring, with Yashasvi Jaiswal taking over the captaincy duties.

“Hopefully it’s not too serious, but a little bit on the hamstring. Thankfully, we have about a week break, so we’ll clear it out,” he added.

RR next face Gujarat Titans here on May 9.

Ticked boxes: Starc

Australia left-arm quick Mitchell Starc played his first game of the season, making a return from a shoulder injury.

Playing his first competitive

match after more than three months, Starc was the pick of DC’s bowlers, returning with 3/40, including the first-over dismissal of Yashasvi Jaiswal.

“Nice to get the cobwebs out. Good to get some running in the legs, get some training in. Nice return... I mean I’ve been bowling for a period of weeks. Haven’t bowled at a batter until three nights ago. In terms of ticking the boxes with the skills, I was in a position to do most of what I want to do.”

For Delhi, the chase was set up by a 110-run opening partnership between KL Rahul (75) and Patum Nissanka (62) as they snapped their three-match losing streak.



Clinical CSK outclass MI by 8 wickets to boost playoff prospects

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Chennai Super Kings produced a thoroughly professional display to outclass Mumbai Indians by eight wickets in a critical Indian Premier League match and significantly boost their playoff prospects here on Saturday.

Afghanistan left-arm spinner Noor Ahmad led a disciplined bowling effort to help CSK restrict a lacklustre Mumbai Indians to 159 for seven.

Noor returned excellent figures of 2/26 in four overs while Anshul Kamboj grabbed 3/32, even as Naman Dhir top-scored for MI with 57 off 37 balls in an insipid display by the visitors after winning the toss.

Captain Hardik Pandya

consumed 23 balls for his 18, reflecting MI’s struggles.

Pandya’s counterpart Ruturaj Gaikwad then led by example with an unbeaten 48-ball 67 and he was well supported by Kartik Sharma (54 not out off 40 balls) and Urvil Patel (24 off 12 balls).

In the chase, CSK’s man in form Sanju Samson was quick off the blocks with a couple of boundaries but Jasprit Bumrah cut short his stay with a beautiful outswinger that took the outside edge and Ryan Rickelton dived to right his to grab the ball.

Samson, who punched Bumrah through covers in the previous delivery, paid the price for his lack of foot movement. Skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad smashed Trent Boult for a six over deep square-leg as 17 runs came off the third over.



I enjoy being a finisher for my team: Ashutosh Sharma

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Delhi Capitals batting all-rounder Ashutosh Sharma said he relishes his role as a finisher after his side snapped a three-match losing streak with a seven-wicket win over Rajasthan Royals in an IPL match here.

Ashutosh struck an unbeaten 25 off 15 balls, hitting four boundaries, as Delhi successfully chased down a daunting 226-run target with five balls to spare on Friday.

“I enjoy being a finisher for my team. The team has trusted me to bat in these situations and I enjoy playing in these moments. I always feel that as long as I am at the crease, I can win the game for my team,” Ashutosh said at the post-match press conference.

Chasing a stiff total, Delhi were laid a solid foundation by KL Rahul and Patum Nissanka, who stitched together a 110-run opening partnership.

“In T20 cricket nowadays, a lot depends on the opening partnership and the power-

play. Our openers played really well and because of that we were in the game throughout and could take it till the end,” Ashutosh said.

Delhi’s overseas pace duo of Mitchell Starc and Kyle Jamieson had earlier set the tone by removing Rajasthan’s explosive openers Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi inside the first two overs.

“We wanted to get their opening partnership out early, as they have been doing well in previous matches. That was our plan and it worked, which was good for us.”

Meanwhile, Rajasthan Royals batting coach Vikram Rathour admitted that poor execution with the ball cost his side the match.

“The bowlers couldn’t execute their plans again today. 226 we felt was enough on this surface, they should have been able to defend that.

“When you are defending that kind of total it is important to have a good powerplay. We gave away lots of runs and didn’t take any wicket,” he said.

DC's Kyle Jamieson handed demerit point for Sooryavanshi send off

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Delhi Capitals pacer Kyle Jamieson has been handed one demerit point for giving a fiery send-off to Rajasthan Royals teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi during their Indian Premier League match here.

“Kyle Jamieson has accumulated one Demerit Point and received a warning for breaching Level 1 of the IPL’s Code of Conduct for Players and Team Officials during Match number 43 against Rajasthan Royals (RR) at the Sai Mansingh Stadium, Jaipur,” an IPL



statement read.

The Kiwi pacer was found to have breached Article 2.5 of the IPL’s Code of

an aggressive reaction from another player in the match.’ The incident occurred in the second over of the first innings, when, after dismissing the 15-year-old Sooryavanshi, Jamieson was found to be close to him in an aggressive manner, which could have provoked an aggressive reaction from the batter.

Jamieson admitted to the offence and accepted the sanction imposed by the Match Referee, Rajeev Seth. The Capitals defeated the Royals by seven wickets to notch their fourth win of the ongoing season here on Friday.

Punjab Kings look to bounce back, Gujarat Titans target third straight win

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Their perfect run finally halted, Punjab Kings will look to ensure the slip does not turn into a slide when they take on Gujarat Titans, who will be targeting a third straight win, in the Indian Premier League here on Sunday.

The Kings were handed a bitter first defeat of the season by Rajasthan Royals earlier this week.

Although Punjab Kings continue to lead the standings with 13 points from eight games, Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Sunrisers Hyderabad and Rajasthan Royals are just a point behind them.

For a side that had set the early pace with six wins on

the trot, the loss has brought a few concerns, especially with the ball.

Punjab’s bowling has not quite matched the consistency of their batting. In fact, their strong batting displays have often masked the shortcomings of the bowling unit.

Even in victories, Punjab’s bowlers have allowed opposition teams to score freely at stages, and the recent loss once again exposed those issues.

Their inability to close out innings has put added pressure on the batters, who have often had to chase bigger targets or set above-par totals.

With the tournament entering a more competitive phase, Punjab will need sharper execution and clearer plans, particularly



against a Gujarat top order that thrives on momentum.

Their fielding has also been a concern with plenty of dropped catches and misfields.

The batting, however, remains Punjab’s biggest strength. Openers Priyansh Arya and Prabhsimran Singh have provided solid starts, while Cooper Connolly has also been among the runs.

The middle order, led by

skipper Shreyas Iyer, has shown enough depth to push totals or finish chases.

Gujarat Titans, meanwhile, come into this match on a two-game winning streak, though their campaign has largely been stop-start.

They have struggled to string together consistent performances, but the recent wins suggest they may be settling into a rhythm.

With back-to-back wins, first over Chennai Super Kings and then RCB, the Titans are fifth on the table with 10 points.

Much of Gujarat’s success with the bat has revolved around their top three — Sai Sudharsan, captain Shubman Gill and Jos Buttler — but over dependence on the trio remains a concern.

Washington Sundar has

shown promise in the middle order, but finishers like Shahrukh Khan and Rahul Tewatia are yet to make a consistent impact.

Jason Holder has also been slotted into the middle order to add balance, and his all-round contribution was evident in the win over defending champions RCB.

The West Indian picked up two wickets for 29 runs from his four overs and also grabbed three catches, underlining his value across departments.

Another encouraging sign for Gujarat has been their bowling in the previous match. The attack looked far more disciplined, with better control over lengths and improved execution in key phases as they bowled out RCB for an under-par 155.

Tim Southee keeps suspense over Pathirana KKR debut

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

A settled Kolkata Knight Riders are weighing their options on handing a much-anticipated debut to Matheesha Pathirana for their away clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Sunday, even as the Sri Lankan pacer has been with the side for two weeks after clearing his fitness test back home, said bowling coach Tim Southee.

The slinky pacer had injured his calf during Sri Lanka’s T20 World Cup match against Australia on February 16 and joined the KKR squad ahead of their home fixture against Rajasthan Royals on May 1 to give a much-needed boost to their depleted pace attack.

KKR have played another match against Lucknow Super Giants since his arrival, but Pathirana who was long awaited by the franchise, is yet



to get a look-in.

“He’s been around the group for a little bit now. We’ll look at conditions and make a decision on the side that we think is best for tomorrow’s game,” said Southee during the pre-match media interaction.

“He’s been bowling well at train-

ing and it’s great to have him a part of the side.” The dilemma could stem from KKR’s reluctance to tinker with a winning combination, having finally put together two consecutive wins after struggling to post a victory for seven matches this season.

Sunil Narine has remained indispensable for KKR since 2012, while Aussie all-rounder Cameron Green is their marquee overseas recruit this season.

That leaves the team to choose between Tim Seifert and Rowman Powell if Pathirana is to be accommodated.

Big-hitting Powell has not quite fired with a highest of 39 not out off 24 balls and a modest strike rate of just over 134 in five innings.

New Zealand opener Seifert on the other hand has struggled after his T20 World Cup exploits, returning scores of 19, 0 and 0 in three outings for KKR.

It has been two weeks since Pathirana joined the squad and has been training regularly, but his lack of competitive match practice — he hasn’t played since the February 16 World Cup game — could also be a factor.

With KKR placed eighth on the table, they can ill afford missteps at this stage in their push for the playoffs.

Southee agreed that multiple factors go into team selection.

“Yes, you take a number of things into consideration for selection. Obviously, the balance of a side, the makeup of your team.

“Here with the IPL, your makeup with the overseas has to change when you make those changes. Those decisions will be taken into account along with the conditions that we’re looking to be faced with tomorrow,” he said.

Up against a top-heavy SRH lineup featuring Travis Head, Abhishek Sharma, Ishan Kishan and Heinrich Klaasen, KKR’s focus will be on winning the Powerplay, Southee said, adding that the bowling group is upbeat after a decent showing in the earlier meeting.



Yellamaraju in top-20

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Doral (US)

Akshay Bhatia dropped a double bogey on his closing hole and slipped to tied 26th at the Cadillac Championship after two rounds, while Sudarshan Yellamaraju (66) was tied 16th after looking good for a top-5 placement.

Yellamaraju was 9-under through 16 holes and dropped three shots, including a double bogey on the 17th.

Saith Theegala also dropped a double on the eighth and bogeys on the third, ninth and the 18th for a 76 and was T-48th. It was a day when the closing holes were tough, particularly the 18th.

Overall Theegala had just one birdie against three bogeys and a double bogey.

Bhatia, who like Theegala is supported by Hero, had a roller coaster of a round with six birdies, four bogeys and a double bogey in his even par 72. Yellamaraju was 9-under for the round through 16 holes before dropping three shots

on his final two holes and finishing with a 66. He is now at 4 under for the week.

Yellamaraju was in the first group of the day and made good use of the calm conditions till he ran into trouble at the finish.

Cameron Young finally made his first bogey of the week but it barely affected his lead going into the weekend.

Young shot a 5-under 67 on Friday to get to 13 under and take a five-shot lead at the midway point of the USD 20 million Signature Event at Trump National Doral.

Young’s lone blemish was a bogey at the par-4 14th, where his chip from an awkward sidehill lie didn’t reach the putting surface. Other than that he was flawless — just as he had a bogey-free 64 a day earlier to grab the lead.

Young played with Scottie Scheffer, the world’s No. 1 player had a bogey-free 67 but ended the day exactly where he started it — seven shots off the lead and in tied sixth place.

In IPL, bowlers need to be aggressive: PBKS' Ferguson

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Punjab Kings pacer Lockie Ferguson says bowlers will get some stick in a high-scoring tournament like IPL but they need to find ways to remain aggressive and restrict the flow of runs to be successful in the gruelling league.

The domination of batters has been so absolute in IPL 2026 that even a target in excess of 230 or even 250 often did not feel safe.

“IPL is just sort of a new competition on its own in the style of cricket that’s played here. It’s obviously high-scoring. So, you’re going to get hit for bound-

aries. That’s part of being a bowler,” Ferguson told media ahead of Punjab’s match against Gujarat Titans.

“It’s how do you bounce back the next ball and try to execute again. So, as long as the bowlers are being aggressive, trying to find ways to get batters out whilst also restricting runs, then they’re going to be in a good mindset,” he added.

So how does a bowler do that — depending on raw pace or variations?

“I mean, extra pace comes with its benefits. Sometimes the faster you bowl, the faster it goes to the rope. But it’s an X-factor. You know, if you can get extra pace, then



obviously the batter has less time to react. “And then, you know, every modern-day cricketer has variables.

ble and trying to learn what’s working on that particular day,” he said.

Ferguson joined PBKS a wee bit late after being with his wife — Emma — to welcome their first child — Beau. The Kiwi quick thanked the franchise for allowing him some family time.

“I chose to have some time at home with my family, my newborn. And, you know, I can’t thank Punjab Kings enough for allowing me to do that. It’s obviously a hard decision from a cricket point of view to take time out to spend it at home,” he said.

But the 34-year-old admitted that joining IPL midway was not an easy job.

“Obviously, it’s not that easy coming from training at home straight into the IPL. It’s a tough competition at the best of times. But, yeah, this is the challenge we face.” The PBKS suffered their first defeat of IPL 2026 when Rajasthan Royals scaled down a 223-run target for a six-wicket win at Mullanpur.

But Ferguson did not read too much into that result.

“Execution is the key, right? So, we’re trying to execute. Some days, not so good. But at the same time, the skill sets that are involved with this bowling attack led by Arshdeep and Chahal, I thought the spinners were fantastic last game.



THE LOST MAGIC

We pretend to worship culture, while ruthlessly bulldozing the very artists who keep it breathing, says SAKSHI PRIYA

How will a society preserve its rich culture if it abandons the exact artists keeping it alive? We need to preserve our culture. We need to preserve the artist. We need to present raw talent to a world starving for real magic. Yet, we watch the lost artist wander a city with zero stage left to stand on.

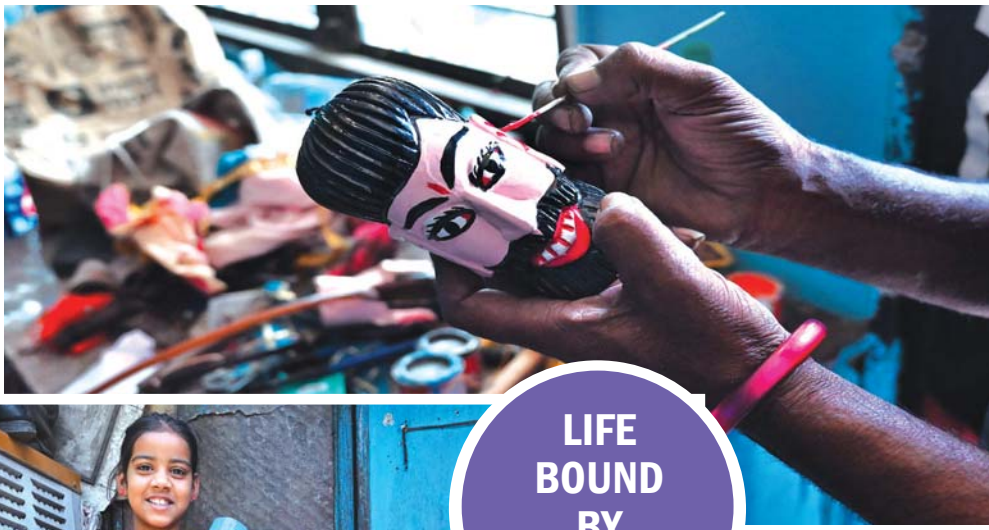
I know fear. I know what it means to sit in deep pain, wanting to speak out, while the soul violently refuses to let a single word escape. Looking at the displaced masters of Kathputli Colony today, I see that exact same suffocating silence hanging over them. Society loves to talk about saving our heritage, yet we willingly abandon the people keeping that history alive. We crave real magic, but we force our most gifted performers to wander a city with absolutely no stage left to stand on.

Decades back, wandering families travelling from Rajasthan found a bare patch of earth near Delhi's Shadipur Depot. They pitched their tents and stayed. Over the years, those fragile tarps grew into a chaotic, dizzying knot of brick walls and tin roofs. Commuters driving past those cramped alleys would label the place a slum and look away, completely blind to the reality breathing inside. The best street performers alive were all in there together, acrobats and magicians and fire-breathers sharing walls and food and air, the whole block so packed and alive it functioned like a single organism. Nobody taught anybody formally. You just

lived there and absorbed it, picked it up through proximity and repetition and years of watching someone better than you do the thing you were trying to learn. People flew in from the other side of the world for this, crossing continents just to stand inside those lanes for a few hours and go home different people. Then the bulldozers came.

Eleven agonising years have passed since that violent day. Everything fractured, and everyone scattered. Kathputli Colony is gone entirely, wiped clean off the city map. These performers are now shoved into the dense, suffocating transit camps of Anand Parbat. The wider public moved on quickly, forgetting the demolition and the uprooted talent. Erasing the people guarding our rich history because their address changed remains a catastrophic cultural failure. Wiping out that physical space destroyed an irreplaceable library of memory.

Master puppeteer Prakash Bhat sits in a stifling room in Anand Parbat, remembering a time when his family commanded global respect. "My father was a puppet king in our colony," Bhat recalls, his voice carrying the heavy weight of a lost empire. "He visited the whole of India and started the Song and Drama Division first. He went to America to perform and build a life there. Rajiv Gandhi was Prime Minister at the time and made a promise, go back to India and your house will be waiting for you. So he



LIFE BOUND BY STRINGS

PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

If Kathputli Colony had stayed standing the younger generation would have grown up the way Prakash Bhat's son grew up, beside the dhol, inside the work, learning by watching and repeating and absorbing it through the walls. That is how this kind of craft lives on, not in classrooms but in proximity, in daily contact with people who have been doing it their whole lives. What is shrinking is not just the art. It is the whole world that made the art possible



went back. The house never came.

Today, those grand stages are a ghost story. Prakash waits hours for a public bus to reach distant wedding gigs, forced to play the drum to put food on the table. His wooden puppets, hand-carved pieces of his own bloodline, sit in unsecured sheds waiting to be stolen. Two months ago, he did a show for two thousand five hundred rupees, left his stage gear in the shed, and came back to find five thousand rupees' worth of equipment gone. He did a show and walked away poorer. That is what he called a double loss.

These masters have zero room to practice or train the youth, threatening the absolute extinction of their craft. Taking their talent to public areas like Connaught Place or India Gate to earn a living invites immediate police harassment. "I want the government to help us get a pass so that we can perform

wherever we want without the police troubling us," Bhat pleads. Without that basic permission, the younger generation will abandon the art entirely, seeing zero financial future in manipulating strings.

The puppets sitting quietly in dark trunks are what the city left behind when it took everything else. These performers lost their homes, their stages, their income, and any platform they ever had, pushed into concrete boxes and told to be grateful. But something in them refused to go quiet. An old master held up a battered marionette in that half-empty camp and said the only thing left worth saying. An artist carries that thing inside them all the way to the end, and it does not go, not when every promise made to them rotted, not when the walls came down, not when the world moved on and forgot there was ever a name to remember.



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

Families who carried generations of art in their hands were simply scattered overnight, forced to trade their heritage for survival. If we actually care about the stories that built this city's cultural landscape, we have to help these displaced artists find a new stage. Until then, it is the artists themselves-their calloused hands, their watchful eyes, their quiet mastery-who remain boxed away in the dark. Their old songs will go unsung, waiting for the day we finally ask them to create once more.



Crafting magic behind the scene



Traditional puppet by hand



Artisan elephants crafted with care

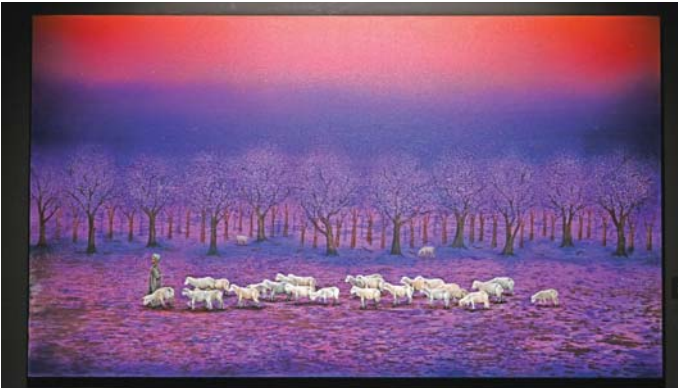
ART CORNER

ART WITHOUT GATEKEEPERS

Kalaa Spandan Art Fair creates a democratic New Delhi hub where creators and collectors meet without the usual gallery middlemen

Bridging the massive gap between raw artistic talent and everyday collectors stands as the central theme of the *Kalaa Spandan Art Fair*. Now in its fourteenth edition, the fair completely transforms New Delhi's Aga Khan Hall into a sprawling, barrier-free celebration of contemporary expression. Organiser Sudip Chakrabarti designed this platform specifically to dismantle traditional gallery gatekeeping. His structure allows visitors to interact face to face with the creators. Across three bustling days in late April, the venue houses over one thousand distinct artworks from more than one hundred twenty participants. The variety commands absolute attention. Intricate traditional watercolours hang right beside bold alcohol ink experiments and heavy oil canvases.

By entirely removing the middlemen, the exhibition creates a truly accessible entry point for new buyers while presenting seasoned connoisseurs with raw, undiscovered talent. The atmosphere remains fiercely independent. Kalaa Spandan successfully strips away the rigid exclusivity of the art world, delivering a profoundly democratic and vibrant cultural exchange.



NATURE'S WARNING

Between delicate watercolours and vivid acrylics, the works reveal beauty laced with tension, reminding us how small and fragile we remain within nature's vast order

Ashish Kushwaha strips the human ego out of the landscape in *Where the Sky Remembers*. Currently running at New Delhi's Palette Art Gallery through May 23, his solo exhibition makes mankind look incredibly small. Drawing on a rural Chhattisgarh upbringing, the artist surrounds fragile human traces like a lone boat or a tiny hut with massive, quiet ecosystems. He trades soft watercolours for thick acrylics without missing a beat, grounding the scenes in sharp greens and unexpected lavenders. The paintings pull you in with raw beauty. Then the unease hits. Kushwaha leaves us with a humbling truth about our place in the wild. We are entirely microscopic.

You see this exact tension alive in the materials themselves. Shifting fluidly between vulnerable, transparent watercolours and heavily opaque acrylics, the artist forces highly charged electric greens to clash with deeply saturated lavenders. The visual payoff is immediate and striking, yet fundamentally anxious. Every canvas operates as a beautiful, brooding cage, quietly amplifying the creeping dread of our fragile footprint on the dirt.

TEAM VIVA

Movement becomes the maze

SAKSHI PRIYA

Ancient stories breathe through our skin, finding a way to beat through the chest of anyone sitting in the dark. We carry these old wars with us, knowing the sharp edges of a sacrifice long before the curtain goes up. The opening night of the *Kendra Dance Festival* at Kamani Auditorium brought us back to that lethal geometry of the Mahabharata.

This year's programming pulls together a curated selection from the *Kendra Dance Repertory*, striking a balance between long-standing tradition and fresh renewal.



It revisits established works alongside reworked productions, where choreography and stage design keep the soul of the original work intact. Chakravyuh stands as a retelling that captures the suffocating pressure of a trap. Seeing Abhimanyu march toward that swirling formation brought a dead silence to the room. Shashidharan Nair's choreography relies on the raw, heavy power of Mayurbhanj Chhau, using those martial movements to pull a whole battlefield out of thin air. Every leap toward the centre carried a raw bravery, a young life held up against a mathematical nightmare.

Shobha Deepak Singh and Gauri S Keeling have built a space where these epics stay alive through a quiet, constant renewal. The ensemble moves in a way that turns their bodies into the very

walls of the maze. They shift in a rhythmic, terrifying pattern that leaves the hero isolated.

The music builds a sprawling landscape that vibrates through the bones of the audience. You catch that exact, hollow isolation that comes from being hemmed in by thousands while being entirely alone in the heart of the struggle. The performance draws on a vocabulary of movement that pulls the fluid grace of Odissi into the heavy weight of Kathakali. Every single shift in weight signals the rising stakes.

The stage setup allows the space to warp, catching that sense of total confusion found in the middle of the battle. As the Kaurava warriors tightened their circle, the drums picked up a frantic pace that mirrored the racing hearts in the seats. The Pandavas were stopped dead at those gates and the tension sat in your chest like something physical. By the time the final moments came the whole auditorium had gone completely still. Monuments fall apart over centuries but the courage of a lone boy gets cut so deep into a city's memory that even the stones carry it forward. This theatre holds that record and keeps it from being lost.

MUSIC

SAKSHI PRIYA

Sufism remains a bridge between the soul and the divine, carrying a historical weight of inclusion and hope through every melody. This tradition finds its strength in the belief that love remains the only true language, providing a space where differences dissolve into a single, soaring pulse of oneness.

At the LTG Auditorium in New Delhi, Sonam Kalra's *Ibadat — Songs of the Mystics* brought this ancient spirit into the modern light. Her performance focused on surrender and divine connection, pulling from the verses of various mystics to weave a remaining warmth across the evening. Watching from the stalls, one sees a musician who treats each note with immense respect. Kalra, a member of the US Grammy Recording, sang with a raw devotion. She

SONAM KALRA BRINGS MYSTICS TO LIFE



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

breathed hope into each verse, and the room stayed captured by her voice. Every shift in her tone signalled a deeper reach into the poetry. She chose each kalaam with an eye on history,

yet her delivery made those centuries-old words feel urgent for our lives today.

Nikhil Soni, the Associate General Manager for the Shiv Nadar Foundation and HCL Group, introduced the evening with a focus on keeping classical traditions relevant. He spoke about the need for a space where Sufi music could connect with a younger crowd. The evening to ensure the essence of tradition remains accessible to new generations.

Kalra reflected on the night as a special moment of shared reflection. She aimed to build a space for equality. Seeing that emotion come alive in the audience was heartening. She viewed every performance as a journey of love. This kind of *Ibadat* stands as the moment we finally choose to surrender to that love. In the soft light of the end, our souls finally found their rest in each other.

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The Pioneer AGENDA

All labor that uplifts humanity has dignity and importance and should be undertaken with painstaking excellence.
— Martin Luther King, Jr



India's sweeping consolidation of labour laws into four Labour Codes marks one of the most consequential shifts in the country's economic governance. The reforms promise streamlined compliance and modernised regulation. But is not the state moving away from its role as protector of labour toward a business facilitator in a market still dominated by informality, stagnant wages, and weak bargaining power

Code on Social Security extends social security benefits like insurance and pensions to gig and platform workers

New labour codes: The reordering of Indian labour relations

Few legislative transformations in recent Indian history have been as consequential or as surreptitiously executed as the consolidation of 44 central labour laws into four Labour Codes. The Codes on Wages, Industrial Relations, Social Security, and Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions were passed with limited deliberation. Their architects described them as a long-overdue rationalisation, a simplification of an unwieldy regulatory thicket, and an instrument for ease of doing business.

Their critics described them as the most fundamental redrawing of the relationship between labour, capital, and the state since Independence. Carefully assessed, beneath the technical language of harmonisation lies a historic shift: the state that positioned itself as a guarantor of workers' rights now appears increasingly to function as a facilitator of employer prerogatives.

The Indian labour market into which these Codes have entered is one of unusual structural distress. According to the Periodic Labour Force Survey for 2024, the all-India labour force participation rate stood at roughly 56 per cent, with female participation in urban areas at a striking 25.8 per cent. The India Employment Report 2024, published by the International Labour Organisation, found that nearly 82 per cent of the workforce remains in the informal sector and almost 90 per cent in informal

employment, a proportion that has scarcely moved in the past decade. Real wages for regular workers have stagnated or declined since 2019, and a majority of casual workers in agriculture and construction did not receive the prescribed daily minimum wage. Against this backdrop, the question is not whether the Codes contain commendable provisions, but whether their architecture can meaningfully reach the workforce that most needs them.

Consider the most-discussed innovation: a four-day workweek with 12-hour shifts. In a knowledge economy or a well-regulated factory, this offers welcome flexibility. In an industrial milieu where compliance with the eight-hour standard is itself uneven, the formalisation of a twelve-hour day risks becoming the new norm rather than a voluntary alternative. The recent wildcat workers' action in Noida, where workers protested twelve-hour, seven-day workweeks and monthly wages of eleven to twelve thousand rupees, is a sobering reminder of what flexibility can look like when bargaining power is absent.

The redefinition of wages, intended to ensure a fairer base, will produce mixed effects. By including basic pay, dearness



MANOJ KUMAR JHA
Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha), Rashtriya Janata Dal

allowance, and retaining house rent and conveyance, the Codes seek to prevent the suppression of provident fund and gratuity contributions through allowance-heavy structures. For many salaried workers, this will mean higher long-term retirement benefits and a meaningfully larger statutory cushion. For employers, it will mean higher immediate liabilities, likely passed on through restructured cost-to-company packages, modestly reduced take-home pay, and slower hiring at the margin. The transition will be uncomfortable but defensible. The deeper concern lies elsewhere in the economy, where the formal salaried workforce is a minority. The architecture of wage protection still leaves the majority of Indian workers, such as daily wagers, agricultural labourers, domestic workers, and the truly informal, so to speak, beyond its operative reach.

The treatment of gig and platform workers illustrates both the ambition and the limits of the new framework. Their formal recognition under the Code on Social Security, with provisions for contributory schemes funded partly by aggregator platforms, is a genuinely path-breaking development. Few major

economies have legislated explicitly for this category. Yet the entitlements remain framed in the conditional voice. The government "may" notify schemes; aggregators "shall" contribute at rates yet to be finalised. As scholars analysing the Codes have observed, the gap between statutory recognition and justiciable entitlement remains wide, and the absence of a clear definition of the employer-employee relationship leaves platform workers vulnerable to algorithmic management without the bargaining tools that traditional employment confers.

On industrial relations, the Codes raise the threshold for prior governmental approval of lay-offs and retrenchments from 100 to 300 workers, and require a 14-day notice for strikes alongside automatic conciliation. The intent is to enable smoother corporate decision-making and to discourage disruptive industrial action.

The effect, as critics across the political spectrum have noted, is a meaningful tilt in bargaining leverage towards employers in an environment where union density is already below two per cent of the enterprise workforce. A genuine reform agenda might have paired flexibility with strengthened collective bargaining, perhaps through sectoral wage boards or stronger recognition mechanisms. The Codes have chosen flexibility without any counterweight.

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NEW LABOUR CODES

These codes were made effective on November 21, 2025, with an aim to balance the welfare of the workforce with industrial growth. These codes replace numerous fragmented acts like the Minimum Wages Act (1948), Factories Act (1948), and Industrial Disputes Act (1947).

CODE ON WAGES (2019):

Establishes a universal minimum wage for all employees in both organised and unorganised sectors. It introduces a "floor wage" set by the central government, below which state-fixed minimum wages cannot fall.

INDUSTRIAL RELATIONS CODE (2020)

Streamlines rules for trade unions, strikes, and dispute settlements. It raises the worker threshold for requiring government approval for layoffs and closures from 100 to 300 workers.

CODE ON SOCIAL SECURITY (2020)

Extends social security benefits like insurance and pensions to gig and platform workers for the first time. It also makes fixed-term employees eligible for pro-rata gratuity after just one year of service, down from five.

OCCUPATIONAL SAFETY CODE (2020)

Sets uniform safety standards and mandates free annual health check-ups for certain employees. It also legally allows women to work night shifts across all establishments with their consent and mandatory safety measures.

KEY CHANGES

50 PER CENT WAGE RULE

An employee's basic pay must now comprise at least 50 per cent of their total CTC. This will increase higher Provident Fund and Gratuity

48-HOUR FULL & FINAL SETTLEMENT

Employers are now mandated to complete the full and final settlement of wages within 48 hours of an employee's resignation, dismissal, or retrenchment

STANDARD WORKING HOURS

Normal working hours remain capped at 8 to 9 hours per day and 48 hours per week, with overtime paid at twice the normal wage rate

FORMALISATION

Appointment letters are now mandatory for all workers, ensuring written proof of employment and social security eligibility

The Economic Survey 2025-26

has made an optimistic projection that the implementation of India's new labour codes shall bring about a major transformative reform with the creation of **77 lakh jobs!**



India's labour codes and new realities for workers

The announcement of the implementation of the four new labour codes on November 21, is a historic move towards promoting a transformational change in the labour regulation framework of the country. As India embarks on its journey towards Vision Viksit Bharat 2047, the economic empowerment and promotion of the well-being of workers remain central and a key driver of the nation's progress. The vision also envisages closing the gender gaps in women's economic participation and improving India's position across global indicators. These codes have simplified 29 labour legislations into four codes, namely: The Code on Wages, 2019; the Industrial Relations Code, 2020; the Code on Social Security, 2020; and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions (OSH) Code, 2020, aimed at better labour regulation, promoting decent work, and ensuring social protection for workers.

The Economic Survey 2025-26 has made an optimistic projection that the implementation of India's new labour codes shall bring about a major transformative reform with the

creation of 77 lakh jobs. But in order to understand what this really means, one has to look at the reality in which these reforms are being rolled out. Over 90 per cent of India's workforce remains trapped in informality, with limited access to social security or regular incomes, along with low female labour force participation. Evidence from the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025 reflects this challenge: while the overall labour force participation rate (LFPR) for those aged 15 and above stands at 59.3 per cent, there is a stark gender divide, with male participation at 79.1 per cent as compared to just 40 per cent for women. Equally concerning has been the imbalance in the nature of employment, with 52 per cent of workers engaged in self-employment and only 23.6 per cent in regular salaried jobs, reflecting a dominance of precarious employment and limited access to social security. Assessing the labour codes amidst these challenges is critical to understand the



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reforms not merely as legislative changes but as an attempt to shift India's workforce to more secure, inclusive, and productive employment - an essential step if the country is to move meaningfully towards the vision of Viksit Bharat. While balancing worker protection and flexibility, the new codes will boost formalisation through the creation of fixed-term employment; enhance social security coverage through portability of benefits; increase female labour force participation; promote ease of doing business with the introduction of single registration, single return, and single licence; and expand employment.

The regularisation of employment contracts through the introduction of Fixed Term Employment (FTE) under the IR Code provides all benefits to FTEs at par with permanent employees, including gratuity after continuous service of one year. Though these provisions can address informality to a large extent and enhance workers' access to social security.

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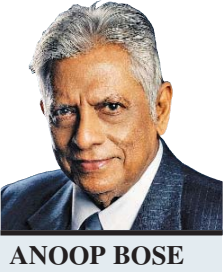
THE EMERGING TRENDS

- Recruiters are increasingly using AI to screen resumes (60 per cent of recruiters), making AI literacy a mandatory skill for job seekers across all domains.
- Hiring is decentralising as Global Capability Centres (GCCs) expand beyond metros.
- There is a significant shift toward skills-based hiring. Certifications in niche areas like DGCA-certified drone piloting command higher premiums than traditional degrees.
- Fixed Term Employment is providing more formal protections than contract labour.
- Female Labour Force Participation reached 41.7 per cent in 2023-24, though a gender gap persists in top executive positions.



“IT IS ALWAYS EASIER TO FIGHT FOR
ONE’S PRINCIPLES THAN TO
LIVE UP TO THEM”
— ALFRED ADLER

Trump: Breaking rules, making history



ANOOP BOSE

On April 25, 2026, an abortive third attempt on President Donald John Trump's life was made at the annual White House Correspondents' Association's Dinner in the glittering Ballroom of the iconic wing-shaped Washington Hilton Hotel by a 31 year old intruder Cole Tomas Allen hailing from Torrance, California. Allen had surreptitiously registered as a guest in the hotel and stealthily managed to descend ten flights of stairs and fully sprint precariously close to the meticulously secured main magnetometer screening area armed to the teeth with a 12-gauge pump-action shotgun, a handgun and multiple knives concealed adroitly in a duffel bag. Trump and other dignitaries were whisked away to safety by the US Secret Service with amazing promptitude and alacrity. Allen was deftly apprehended and arrested by US Secret Service agents, but not before he had shot a US Secret Service Agent who was miraculously saved by a whisker, thanks to his efficacious ballistic protective vest. In a hastily convened press conference at the White House, a visibly emotional Trump, still attired in his formal black tuxedo, described the "would be assassin" as a "lone wolf" and a "very sick person" and went on to assert, "And this was an event dedicated to freedom of speech that was supposed to bring together members of both parties with members of the press. And in a certain way it did because the fact that they just unified, I saw a room that was just totally unified." The bizarre incident is the latest in an alarming spike in global political violence in recent years and comes amid escalating hate, extremism and polarisation. US politicians from across the aisle and world leaders have expressed their condemnation in one voice. Our Prime Minister Narendra Damodardas Modi lost no time in expressing his traditional solidarity with Trump, "Relieved to learn that President Trump, the First Lady and Vice President are safe and unharmed following the recent security incident at a Washington DC hotel. I extend my best wishes for their continued safety and well-being. Violence has no place in a democracy and must be unequivocally condemned." On April 27th, 2026, a handcuffed, shaken Allen was produced in the Washington Federal Court and charged by the US Magistrate Judge Matthew J. Sharbaugh with attempting to assassinate the US President. Consequently, Allen faces the caliginous prospect of a life sentence if convicted! The matter now rests with the Gujarat born Judge Moxila A Upadhyaya. The incident has taken a dramatic turn after Laura Elizabeth Loomer, the firebrand American far-right political activist and conspiracy theorist, candidly claimed that Allen was a registered Democrat and a Kamala Harris donor. In a roughly 20-minute interview hosted by CBS's flagship anchor Norah O'Donnell, Trump too framed Democrats as the cause of the political violence aimed at him. Not to be outdone, the princess-like White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt (she is ready to have her second baby girl "any minute") blamed the rhetoric from prominent Democrats, "This political violence stems from a systemic demonization of him and his supporters by commentators, by elected members of the Democrat party and even some in the media." All this and more have sparked a major political firestorm.

Now that Trump has had a close shave and the immediate threat to his life has been neutralised forthwith by the grace of Lord Almighty, it will be well worth it incisively retracing his incredible life journey from the glamorous New York real estate Moghul to the mighty, maverick President of the United States. Trump was born literally with a platinum spoon at 10:54 am at the famed Jamaica Hospital ensconced in the Queens borough of New York City on June 14th, 1946 on the very same day Bernard Baruch, the prodigious Jewish American financier and statesman, presented the pioneering "Baruch Plan" aimed at establishing international control over nuclear weapons and technology to prevent nuclear proliferation to the United Nations Atomic Energy Commission. His father Frederick Christ Trump, born to German immigrant parents from Kallstadt, Bavaria, was a wealthy real estate developer and businessman, and his Scottish born mother Mary Anne MacLeod was a well known philanthropist and socialite. Trump, the fourth of five children, initially



attended the co-educational private Kew-Forest School in the neighbourhood of Forest Hills in Queens. Thereafter, his father enrolled him in the New York Military Academy, a private, college preparatory, boarding school in Cornwall, New York. He spent his first two years of college at New York City's top-ranked private Jesuit research Fordham University, before completing his education at the University of Pennsylvania's Wharton School of Finance and Commerce (known now as the Wharton School) in May, 1968 with a Bachelor of Science degree in Economics. After graduation, Trump returned to New York City and commenced working for his father's flourishing real estate business. In 1971, he became the President of a conglomerate of family-owned businesses, which he later named the Trump Organization and began acquiring and building skyscrapers, hotels, golf courses and casinos all over the United States. He also purchased sports teams, published books and served as the producer and host of a reality TV show called The Apprentice. He married his third wife Melania Knauss, the stunning Slovenian born fashion model, on January 22nd, 2005, at the Episcopal Church of Bethesda-by-the-Sea in Palm Beach, Florida, followed by a magical reception at his sprawling Mar-a-Lago estate.

On June 16th, 2015, Trump announced he was running for President as a Republican nominee. Trump's opponent in the 2016 election was the front runner Hillary Diane Rodham Clinton, the former Secretary of State and wife of the 42nd US President William Jefferson "Bill" Clinton. After winning the election in 2026, Trump was sworn in as the 45th President of the United States on January 20th, 2017 and vowed to follow his campaign slogan and achieve his long-cherished dream to "Make America Great Again".

On 15th November, 2022, Trump officially announced his candidacy for the 2024 election. After Joseph Robinette "Joe" Biden Jr opted out of the Presidential race, the former Vice President

Kamala Devi Harris became the official Democratic nominee for the White House. Trump vanquished Harris on November 6th, 2024 and succeeded in becoming the first person to win a nonconsecutive term since President Stephen Grover Cleveland in 1892. On a freezing afternoon of 20th January, 2025, Trump was sworn in for a second term as the 47th President of the United States within the majestic confines of the US Capitol Rotunda in Washington, DC, with his First Lady Melania proudly holding a pair of Bibles viz. The "Trump Bible" (the 1953 edition of the King James version presented to Trump by his mother in 1955!) and the "Lincoln Bible" (that was used by President Abraham Lincoln, the towering sixteenth President of the United States, at his inauguration on March 7th, 1861). In his strikingly flamboyant inauguration speech, Trump addressed his fellow Americans in ringing tones :

"I return to the presidency confident and optimistic that we are at the start of a thrilling new era of national success...Just a few months ago, in a beautiful Pennsylvania field, an assassin's bullet ripped through my ear. But I felt then and believe even more so now that my life was saved for a reason. I was saved by God to make America great again...Today is Martin Luther King Day...We will make his dream come true. The American dream will soon be back and thriving like never before. America will reclaim its rightful place as the greatest, most powerful, most respected nation on earth, inspiring the awe and admiration of the entire world...We are one people, one family, and one glorious nation under God...We will be prosperous, we will be proud, we will be strong, and we will win like never before. We will not be conquered, we will not be intimidated, we will not be broken, and we will not fail. From this day on, the United States of America will be a free, sovereign, and independent nation. We will stand bravely, we will live proudly, we will dream boldly, and nothing will stand in our way because we are Americans. The future is ours, and our golden

age has just begun."

Immediately after the inauguration, Trump proudly reinstated the bronze bust of Sir Winston Leonard Spencer-Churchill (whose American mother Jeanette Jerome was born in Cobble Hill in Brooklyn, the most populous borough of New York City!) chiselled in 1947 by the legendary American-British sculptor Sir Jacob Epstein in the Oval Office, a notable move that highlighted his indefatigable admiration for the titanic British wartime leader who had famously quipped to the US Congress on December 26th, 1941, "I cannot help reflecting that if my father had been American and my mother British, instead of the other way round, I might have got here on my own".

The United States today faces an unprecedented fiscal challenge, with national debt crossing roughly \$39-40 trillion, a level widely described as unsustainable by economists. While this debt crunch is indeed the cumulative result of multiple administrations over decades, the urgency to address it has intensified under Trump. However, the strategy being pursued is complex, controversial, and often appears disconnected from the avowed goal of debt reduction.

One key pillar of Trump's approach on the economic plane has been his aggressive tariff policies. The idea is to generate revenue from imports and reduce dependence on foreign goods. While tariffs have significantly increased government coffers, they still account for only a minuscule fraction of total federal revenues and are far from sufficient to meaningfully reduce the national debt. Moreover, tariffs often act as indirect taxes on consumers, raising domestic prices and risking retaliatory trade wars that have the potentiality of hurting exports and economic growth.

Simultaneously, geopolitical actions-particularly in the aftermath of the ongoing raging conflict with Iran-have added further strain. Military



Our Prime Minister, Narendra Damodardas Modi, lost no time in expressing his traditional solidarity with Trump: "Relieved to learn that President Trump, the First Lady, and the Vice President are safe and unharmed following the recent security incident at a Washington, DC, hotel."

operations are extremely costly, with tens of billions of dollars already spent and the projections of much higher future expenditures. Rather than reducing debt, such conflicts tend to expand deficits, especially when coupled with increased defence budgets.

Trump's stance on NATO also fits into this broader framework. By pressuring allies to contribute more financially and militarily, the administration aims to reduce the American burden in global security. While this could theoretically lower long-term expenditures, it has strained alliances and created uncertainty in the realm of global geopolitics. In essence, while these policies-tariffs, military actions, and alliance restructuring-can be interpreted as attempts to rebalance America's economic and strategic position, they do not yet provide a coherent or sufficient solution to the debt crisis. In fact, many analysts argue that current actions may be exacerbating the very problems they aim to solve.

However, Trump has an indefinable affection and admiration for India and shares a very special fraternal relationship with Modi. On April 23rd, 2026, Trump praised India in effusive terms and reiterated, "India is a great country with a very good friend of mine at the top". The genesis of Modi's personal friendship with Trump took off on 26th June, 2017, when Modi met the newly elected Trump in the course of his fifth official visit to the United States as Prime Minister. On September 22nd, 2019, Modi, in the course of his sixth visit, made a Bollywood-style appearance at the

famed Houston NRG stadium at a truly historic "Howdy, Modi : Shared Dreams, Bright Futures" event. Trump landed in Ahmedabad, Gujarat, on February 24th, 2020, to a red carpet welcome for his first official visit to India and Modi invited him to the newly constructed Motera Cricket Stadium (now known as the Narendra Modi Stadium) to a spectacular event, showcased as "Namaste Trump", graced by over 100,000 ecstatic, wildly cheering Indians. Modi's seventh visit, following Trump's second term in office, was marked by Trump graciously hosting Modi for an Official Working meeting in the White House on February 13th, 2025. Four days later, Trump warmly wished Modi on the eve of his diamond birthday on September 17th, 2025. In the wake of the raging conflict in West Asia, Modi, as a true "foul weather" friend of Trump, has unobtrusively impressed upon Trump that peace was the imperative need of the hour reverberating Mahatma Gandhi's timeless philosophy of peace, "There is no way to peace; peace is the way." Significantly, Trump had a 90 minute long telephonic dialogue with Putin traversing a wide range of global flashpoints including the Iran war, the Ukraine conflict and the recent shooting in Washington, virtually reigniting the 15th August, 2025 Alaska flame! In his commentary, the senior Russian diplomat Yuri Viktorovich Ushakov, Putin's Aide on foreign policy issues and the former Russian Ambassador to the US, lauded the telephonic tête-à-tête as "friendly and businesslike" and expressed that Putin had strongly condemned the assassination attempt against Trump stressing that any form of politically motivated violence was unacceptable.

Even though Modi told Trump in a touching telephonic conversation that lasted for nearly 40 minutes on April 14th, 2026 that the "people of India love you", Trump has multifarious antagonists, detractors, baiters and denigrators in India and some prominent Indian TV channels and self-styled Indian political commentators, reputed to have close connections with giant corporate houses and the powers that be in India, have maliciously unleashed a blistering campaign of vilification and calumny against Trump with impunity to subvert the narrow vested interests of venturous political parties and nations inimical to Trump and Uncle Sam. Such unscrupulous persons and TV channels will undoubtedly cast a dark and foreboding shadow on the warm and cordial relations that exist between India and the United States!

The author is an internationally reputed senior lawyer practising in the Supreme Court of India and various High Courts and Tribunals in India. He is an avid debater, public speaker, writer, broadcaster, telecaster, artist, painter, sculptor, music critic and filmmaker

FROM AGENDA COVER

The reordering of Indian labour relations

Common definitions, fewer registrations, unified returns, and the reconstitution of inspectors as facilitators reduce regulatory friction in ways that small and medium enterprises have long demanded. Whether this translates into greater employment generation is less certain. The empirical evidence linking labour-law flexibility to job creation in India is mixed at best, and the binding constraints on Indian employment growth, such as weak demand, capital-intensive production, the absence of sufficient mid-skilled jobs, and the rural-urban divide in opportunity, lie largely beyond the labour code framework.

The Indian Constitution, in its directive principles, envisions the state as an active agent in securing humane working conditions, a living wage, and workers' participation in the management of industry. These commitments do not bind the legislature in a strict legal sense, but they articulate a moral horizon. To move steadily away from that horizon, in the name of efficiency or competitiveness, is to alter the implicit compact between citizen and state. Labour, in the Indian constitutional imagination, was a domain of dignity, of social belonging, and of democratic participation, not just a market input. The Codes, whatever their administrative virtues, mark a retreat from that vision. Whether the



Indian republic chooses to recover it or to ratify its erosion will shape not only its labour relations but also its larger understanding of what economic citizenship is meant to mean. India requires a sustained politics of labour: Investment in skilling, demand-side stimulation of formal job creation, mechanisms for genuine collective bargaining, and an extension of social protection that does not stop at statutory recognition but reaches the worker on the construction site, in the field, and at the delivery doorstep.

India's labour codes...

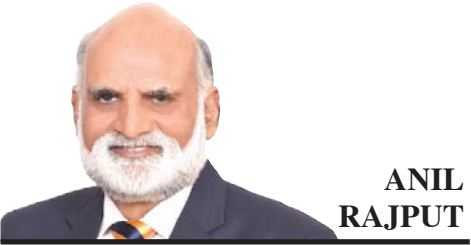
However, the labour codes have extended their purview to both organized and unorganized workers while extending universal minimum wage across employments in these sectors. The Code on Wages 2019 prohibits any kind of wage discrimination and proscribes gender discrimination by promoting equal pay for equal work. This provision is aligned with ILO's Equal Remuneration Convention No 100 to which India has been a signatory. At the same time, the fixation of floor wages

based on local living standards in different regions will contribute in addressing inequality. Drawing inspiration from various gender equality Conventions of the ILO, the labour codes offer unique opportunity for women and can act as a powerful mechanism in unlocking women's economic potential towards realizing the goals of Viksit Bharat 2047. Enhanced maternity protection of 26 weeks maternity leave under Social Security Code, surpasses ILO's Maternity Protection Convention 183, 2000 which had stipulated 14 weeks of maternity leave. Several gender sensitive provisions like mandatory creche facilities for establishments with 50 or more employees, work from home and leave provisions extended to surrogate as well as adoptive mothers are important for encouraging women to sustain in the labour force. The extension of social security benefits for Gig and Platform workers had remained central to the G20 deliberations under India's G20 Presidency in 2023. Building on this commitment, the Union Budget 2025-26 has announced several key measures for welfare of gig and platform workers viz their registration in E-shram portal, issuing identity cards and extending health coverage. Under the SS Code aggregators are now required to contribute 1-2% of their annual turnover to a Social Security Fund which would finance a range of welfare schemes for these workers who were previously left without protection.

The Reskilling Fund under the IR Code for

retrenched workers provides financial grant equal to 15 days of their last drawn wages. This provides an opportunity for the workers to upskill, improve their employability and prepare themselves for the future labour market by learning new technologies. The OSH Code has extended protection to a large group of migrant workers by widening the definition of migrant workers to include both who have come through contractors and on their own. Practical measures like a toll-free helpline and the portability of the public distribution system can address vulnerability of these workers who are away from support networks. At the same time, the code opens up employment opportunities for women workers by promoting night shifts for women with their consent along with provisions of transportation facility and protection against workplace harassment. Under the new labour codes, compliance is ensured through simplification, digital interventions and increased accountability. While the codes are envisioned at reshaping India's labour landscape through promoting economic growth and strengthening workers welfare, their real impact will unfold in the coming years. Much will depend on how effectively the Centre and States co-ordinate in implementation of these codes. As the States are finalising the rules, the challenge is now to ensure that the reform translates into transformative changes in the lives of workers as envisioned in the ideals of Viksit Bharat.

Rabindranath Tagore jayanti: A celebration of literature, culture, and Bengal's living cuisine



ANIL
RAJPUT

Rabindranath Tagore Jayanti is not merely the commemoration of the birth anniversary of one of Bharat's most luminous minds, but a celebration of the spiritual and humanistic milieu he inspired. A poet, philosopher, composer, educationist, artist, and institution-builder his work continues to shape the moral and cultural imagination of the nation. He was the first non-European to win the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913 for his collection of poems, Gitanjali: Song Offerings, and is credited for composing India's national anthem, 'Jana Gana Mana,' besides Bangladesh's, 'Amar Shonar Bangla.' During his lifetime he pioneered a holistic, nature-based education, in Shatniketan that blended the best of Eastern and Western ideals that continues to be nurtured till the present time.

Born on 7 May 1861, corresponding to 25 Boishakh in the Bengali calendar, at the Jorasanko Thakur Bari in Kolkata, Tagore belonged to a family that stood at the heart of Bengal's intellectual and cultural renaissance. The Tagore household was not merely a residence, but a centre of music, literature, theatre, reformist thought, and artistic exchange. Over time, his legacy came to be associated not only with literary genius, but also with a refined way of living in which art, nature, education, hospitality, and simplicity were held together. Rabindra Jayanti, therefore, is observed with both reverence and warmth not only in his birthplace but across the nation with cultural pride, affection, and collective memory.

The special occasion invites a distinctive cuisine known for its refinement and celebration of Bengali taste and seasonal sensitivity. Rice, lentils, vegetables, fish, curd, mango, coconut, milk, and cooling drinks form its core and unfolds gradually, course by course, allowing each preparation to be admired and relished as part of our common civilization.

A traditional meal often begins with shukto, one of Bengal's most distinctive preparations. Made with bitter gourd, raw banana, drumstick, potato, brinjal, and sometimes bori (sun-dried dumplings made with ground lentils), it is cooked with a mild, creamy base flavoured with mustard, ginger, and a touch of panch phoron (whole spice blend of cumin, mustard, fenugreek, nigella and fennel). Served with plain steamed rice, shukto reflects the Bengali understanding that a meal should begin with restraint before moving toward richness.

From there, the meal moves naturally toward lentils and vegetable preparations that give it a nutritious foundation. Bhaja moong dal is made by dry-roasting split yellow moong dal before cooking it with a tempering of cumin, ginger, bay leaf, and ghee that lifts the dish without making it heavy. Cholar dal brings a more festive note, prepared from Bengal gram and often enriched with pieces of coconut, raisins, bay leaf, cumin, dried red chilli, and ginger. These dals appear as dignified dishes with their own personality and not as mere accompaniments. They provide not only comfort and nutrition but add to the mood of celebration.

Vegetables play an equally important role, and begun bhaja is among the simplest yet most rel-

ished preparations on the menu. Brinjals are sliced and sprinkled with turmeric and salt, sometimes lightly dusted with rice flour, and shallow-fried till they are crispy on the edges while retaining a softer texture. It accompanies dal and rice, and provides a savoury contrast with its smoky taste. Aloo posto, cooked with a paste of poppy seeds, green chillies, and mustard oil, creates a dish that is creamy, nutty, and gently pungent. It is especially suited to the summer months because it is light, cooling, and deeply comforting.

Mochar ghonto adds a more elaborate vegetarian dimension. Prepared from banana blossoms, it requires patience, as the florets must be cleaned carefully before being chopped and cooked with potatoes, coconut, spices, and sometimes chick-peas. The result is earthy, fragrant, and layered. The dish reflects Bengal's gift for transforming humble ingredients into something festive and dignified. Similarly, dhokar dalna, made from steamed and fried cakes of ground chana dal cooked in a light gravy, offers richness and a healthy dose of proteins. The meal then expands into more festive territory with luchi and alur dom, a combination beloved across Bengal. Luchi is made from refined flour kneaded into a soft dough, rolled into small discs, and fried until it puffs into delicate golden rounds while alur dom, prepared with potatoes simmered in a spiced tomato or yogurt-based gravy, provides warmth and aroma. The potatoes absorb cumin, ginger, chilli, and garam masala, becoming rich without losing their homely character. Together, luchi and alur dom carry the comfort of Bengali hospitality, where guests are welcomed with familiar dishes prepared carefully and served generously.

Basanti pulao gives the meal a more ceremonial feel. Made with gobindobhog rice, known for its aromatic, fragrant and sticky texture, it is ideal for festive dishes like pulao, biryani, and payesh (rice pudding). Cooked with ghee, turmeric or saffron, bay leaf, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom, cashews, and raisins, it is mildly sweet, and visually festive especially suited to celebratory meals and pairs well with richer dishes. On Rabindra Jayanti, where the mood is one of refinement rather than loud festivity, basanti pulao sits naturally within the meal, graceful, fragrant, and quietly celebratory.

Fish remains central to the Bengali festive imagination, and macher jhol is among its most recognizable expressions. Prepared with rohu, katla, or other freshwater fish, the curry is usually light, flavoured with turmeric, cumin, ginger, green chilli, and sometimes tomatoes or vegetables such as potato and cauliflower. On a warm May afternoon, macher jhol speaks of Bengal's riverine culture, where fish is not an occasional luxury, but a marker of daily life, ecology, and identity.

The connection between the Bard and his fondness for fish, finds its way into the famed Bengali's cuisine through the recipes of the Thakurbari, the Tagore family home.

In this context, ilish mach, or hilsa, acquires special significance. Preparations such as doi ilish, cooked in a gently spiced yogurt gravy, and ilish narkol dudh diye, prepared with coconut milk, reflect the refined balance of

“UNDERSTANDING OUR RELATIONSHIP TO EATING CULTIVATES A LOT OF INSIGHTS AND HELPS US START LIVING OUR HIGHEST POTENTIAL”
— NATASHA PANTOVIC

richness, delicacy, and seasonal taste associated with Bengali cooking. Their inclusion gives the Rabindra Jayanti table a deeper historical resonance, linking the festive meal not only to Bengal's riverine identity, but also to the remembered culinary world of Jorasanko.

For a richer preparation, chingri malai curry brings elegance to the table. Prawns are cooked in coconut milk with whole spices, ginger, turmeric, and a gentle sweetness that gives the dish its signature softness. The gravy is creamy but not aggressive, allowing the sweetness of the prawns to remain central. Paired with basanti pulao, it creates a sense of occasion while preserving the grace associated with Bengali dining. Another treasured preparation is paturi, in which fish fillets, often bhetki or hilsa when available, are coated with a paste of mustard, green chilli, coconut, turmeric, and mustard oil, then wrapped in banana leaves and steamed or pan-cooked. When opened at the table, the banana leaf releases a warm fragrance, and the fish remains moist, sharp, and aromatic. Paturi is almost poetic in its method, revealing its beauty only when unwrapped and shared.

In many homes, kosha mangsho may also appear, particularly when the celebration becomes a larger family gathering. Mutton is slow-cooked with onions, ginger, garlic, yogurt, and spices until the gravy turns dark, thick, and deeply flavoured. It is not a dish to be rushed. Its richness comes from time, patience, and careful stirring, as the meat absorbs the masala and becomes tender. Served with luchi, pulao, or rice, kosha mangsho adds grandeur to the festive meal. Yet even here, the Bengali table retains balance, as heavier dishes are often placed alongside lighter vegetables, dal, chutney, and curd.

No Bengali celebration feels complete without chutney, and on Rabindra Jayanti, mango chutney is especially appropriate because of the season. Raw or semi-ripe mangoes are cooked with sugar or jaggery, panch phoron, dried red chilli, and sometimes raisins or dates. The result is sweet, tangy, and gently spiced. Traditionally served toward the end of the savory course, mango chutney prepares the palate for sweets. Tomato khejur chutney, made with tomatoes and dates, may also be served, offering a glossy, sweet-sour finish. These chutneys are not merely condiments. They mark the transition from the meal's savory movement to its sweeter conclusion.

The sweet course is where Bengal's culinary imagination becomes especially expressive.

Payesh, made by slow-



cooking rice in milk with sugar or jaggery, cardamom, bay leaf, and sometimes nuts and raisins, is among the most cherished preparations. In many Bengali homes, payesh is associated with birthdays, auspicious beginnings, and affectionate remembrance, making it particularly meaningful on the birth anniversary of Rabindranath Tagore. Served in small bowls, it carries the warmth of blessing and memory.

Sandesh, made from fresh chhena kneaded with sugar and shaped into delicate forms, is another essential sweet. It may be plain, flavoured with cardamom, decorated with pistachio, or infused with seasonal mango. Unlike heavier sweets, sandesh is soft, elegant, and lightly sweet, reflecting the refined taste often associated with Bengal's cultural gatherings. Rasgulla, prepared from chhena balls cooked in light sugar syrup, brings a different kind of joy. Its spongy texture and syrupy sweetness make it one of Bengal's most famous offerings, and it remains a favourite at public functions and household celebrations alike.

Mishti doi adds coolness and depth to the sweet spread. Milk is reduced, sweetened with caramelized sugar or jaggery, and then set with curd culture until it becomes thick and creamy. Served chilled, it is especially welcome in May, when the heat calls for cooling foods. Pantua, made from chhena or khoya, shaped into balls, fried, and soaked in sugar syrup, brings a richer sweetness to the table. Malpua, prepared from a batter of flour, milk, fennel, and sometimes mashed banana, is fried and dipped in syrup, creating a dessert that is crisp at the edges and soft within.

Patishapta, a delicate crepe filled with coconut and jaggery or kheer, may also be included in homes that enjoy bringing a wider range of traditional sweets to the occasion. Aam doi, made by blending mango pulp



sweetened curd, offers a seasonal variation that feels both festive and refreshing. The beverages of the day complete the summer character of the celebration. Aam panna, made from roasted or boiled raw mango pulp, sugar, salt, cumin, and mint, provides relief from the heat while echoing the seasonal presence of mango. Gondhoraj lebu sharbat, prepared with the fragrant Bengali lime, water, sugar, and a pinch of salt, is light, aromatic, and refreshing. Bel sharbat, made from the pulp of wood apple, is valued for its cooling quality and is often consumed during the hot months. Daab erjol, or tender coconut water, offers natural simplicity, while ghol, a lightly salted or sweetened buttermilk, helps balance a rich meal. Tea remains part of Bengali cultural life as well. A cup of masala chai or lightly brewed milk tea may accompany morning rehearsals, poetry readings, or evening gatherings, connecting the formal observance of the day with everyday conversation.

Though enjoyed throughout the year, this cuisine acquires a deeper cultural and emotional resonance during the celebration as it is prepared with memory and sensitivity. There is respect for the season, affection for guests and, importantly, pride in regional inheritance. In its progression, one sees the spirit of Bengal itself, thoughtful, artistic, hospitable, and deeply attached to memory.

Rabindranath Tagore gave India and the world a language of beauty, freedom, and human dignity. His Jayanti reminds us that culture is not preserved only in books, songs, and institutions, but also in the everyday practices through which families remember, gather, cook, serve, and share. The meal prepared on this day becomes a tribute not only to Gurudev's genius, but also to the civilization that nurtured him. I believe that at a time when inherited traditions are often reduced to occasional remembrance, Rabindra Jayanti offers an important call to action and reminds us to preserve the songs, stories, recipes, languages, and customs that have shaped our collective identity, and to pass them on with care to future generations. To celebrate such cuisine, therefore, becomes our shared responsibility to honour the past, enrich the present, and ensure that the cultural inheritance of Bharat remains alive in the homes and hearts of those who will carry it forward.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Soulful plates, thoughtful dining experience



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

In a city that thrives on excess, Kiara Soul Kitchen offers something quietly radical: food that nourishes without compromising on flavour, and an experience that lingers well beyond the last bite. Tucked away in the lively lanes of Greater Kailash 2, Kiara Soul Kitchen offers an experience that feels less like dining out and more like stepping into a thoughtfully curated philosophy of food. From the moment you enter, the restaurant sets a tone of calm sophistication—earthy textures, soft

lighting, and an understated elegance that immediately distances it from the usual bustle of Delhi's dining scene.

The ambience is warm without being overwhelming. There's a conscious effort to create a space where conversations flow easily and meals are savoured slowly. Natural elements subtly echo the brand's wellness philosophy—greens, wooden finishes, and an open, breathable layout that makes you feel instantly at ease. The service complements this setting with quiet efficiency. The staff is attentive yet unobtrusive, striking that fine balance between guiding you through the menu and allowing you to explore at

your own pace. Their knowledge of ingredients and preparation methods stands out, especially when explaining the restaurant's commitment to clean, mindful cooking—no MSG, minimal processing, and a reliance on natural sweeteners and seasonings.

The food, however, is the true highlight. Each dish reflects a careful balance between innovation and comfort. The OG Black Rice is a revelation—nutty, wholesome, and deeply satisfying. The Made-to-Order Green Thai Curry brings a fresh vibrancy, while dishes like the Shakarkandi Kebab and Sprouts Galouti Kebab cleverly reinterpret familiar textures in a plant-forward format. Even something as simple as a soup—whether the Mushroom Velouté or the Tomato with Indonesian herbs—feels elevated through thoughtful layering of flavours.

THE OG BLACK RICE IS A REVELATION—NUTTY, WHOLESOME, AND DEEPLY SATISFYING



Desserts deserve a special mention. The Baked Gulab Jamun, in particular, reimagines a classic indulgence into something lighter yet equally gratifying, staying true to the restaurant's philosophy of mindful indulgence. What sets Kiara Soul Kitchen apart is not just its menu, but its intent. Founded by Madhav Windlass and Manav Windlass, the restaurant fills a noticeable gap in India's dining landscape—where vegetarian cuisine is not just traditional or casual, but refined, global, and health-conscious.



When flavours meet culinary storytelling

TEAM AGENDA

In the evolving landscape of fine dining, Maya emerges as a thoughtfully crafted experience that goes beyond the plate. Conceived in September 2024, the restaurant is the brainchild of Chef Pradeep, whose 25-year culinary journey across diverse cultures has shaped a concept rooted in both tradition and innovation. At Maya, heirloom Indian recipes meet Spanish culinary traditions, creating a menu that explores surprising similarities while cele-



brating distinct regional identities.

At the core of Maya lies its philosophy, 'The Irresistible Allure of Hidden Flavours.' This idea transforms dining into an immersive act of discovery. Inspired by the concept of light refraction—where perception shifts to reveal unseen dimensions—the restaurant encourages guests to engage with food in new and unexpected ways. Each dish is carefully designed to evoke curiosity, blending memory, technique, and creativity to deliver flavours that unfold gradually, much like a story.

Maya embraces a small-plate dining format, drawing inspiration from India's traditional thali culture and Spain's convivial tapas style. This approach fosters

interaction and shared experiences at the table. Signature dishes such as Chenna Pearls with Summer Gazpacho, Prawn Thecha, Duck Sukka, Tawa Gucchi Paprika Hemp Chaat, and the inventive Maya Paella highlight a playful yet refined culinary philosophy. Every plate balances textures, temperatures, and presentation, engaging multiple senses simultaneously. Complementing the food is a thoughtfully curated beverage programme, where cocktails are designed to enhance and elevate the dining journey.

Spread across 7,000 square feet in Gurgaon, the restaurant's interiors mirror its culinary ethos. A seamless blend of Indian warmth and Spanish elegance defines the space, with carefully curated lighting, décor, and layout creating an ambience that is both inviting and layered. The design remains understated, allowing the food to remain the focal point while subtly guiding guests through an experience of discovery.

FLAVOURS SHINE THROUGH PAELLA AND THECHA



The peculiar connection between Love and Discipline

There is no need for a rule or law when there is love. Lovers don’t abide by rules.
Rules are a matter of the head

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Love and discipline are so opposite in nature. You may have noticed that you don't have to discipline yourself to do something which you love. Where there is interest, there is no need for discipline. There is no need for a rule or law when there is love. Lovers don't abide by rules. Rules are a matter of the head.

But at the same time, you cannot discard discipline. You cannot discard the law. Don't think just conflicts create chaos. Love also creates confusion and chaos. Even to maintain love, you need certain discipline. People who are in love, they don't care when they eat, when they sleep, or what they do. In a state of ecstatic love, nothing interests you. But discipline is required where it doesn't interest you.

Discipline and balance are needed in your professional life as well. Sometimes you love doing something, and in pursuit of it, you don't eat properly or sleep properly for a very long time. The body has only a certain amount of elasticity. After that, you are bound to collapse.

There is a saying in Sanskrit, 'Aati Sarvatra varjayet'. It is important to do everything in moderation. For example, whether it is in love or communication, one has to exercise moderation. When you love somebody, you overwhelm them, you suffocate them, you talk too much so that they won't run away from you. Instead, have some discipline and exercise some restraint. That is the way to preserve love. Otherwise, even love turns sour. Six months or a year into it, why do many love marriages end up in separation? It is not those where the love was lukewarm, but even those where it was intense. The latter got into trouble because they expressed everything too much. They didn't observe certain disciplines. They didn't get centred back into themselves, and the focus always remained on the other.

Even in worldly matters, or day-to-day activities like eating food, exercising, walking, etc, follow certain rules, certain discipline. You may not like it, but still do it, for that will uphold you in the long run. Rules and discipline are there to be broken sometimes. For example, in case of emergencies, police, firefighters, and drivers of ambulance vans can violate traffic rules. However, they exercise this freedom only when it is needed. But the provision to break rules should also exist for the sake of the larger good. Here, you must apply your discretion.

Does discipline kill freedom or enhance it?

At first glance, discipline seems to stifle freedom. However, it actually gives you more freedom. For example, it is so difficult for a child to brush their teeth every day if their moms don't insist. And this discipline frees them from teeth-related problems. See the other side of the discipline. It brings you freedom in the long run-freedom from tooth pain.

And only freedom can elevate you to Divine Love. Sage Narada says in his 'Bhakti Sutras', 'Divine love (bhakti) isn't merely emotional, but requires disciplined focus and commitment to be sustained.' Any practice, when it is done over a period of time without any gap, steadily, and with a sense of honor, only then does it firmly establish itself. 'Shasna' means rules that



“DISCIPLINE ISN’T TORTURING ONESELF FOR NOTHING. THERE IS NO DISCIPLINE. THE PURPOSE OF DISCIPLINE IS TO ATTAIN JOY. DO YOU SEE THE DIFFERENCE?”
— GURUDEV



DISCIPLINE IS NEEDED WHERE SOMETHING ISN'T VERY CHARMING IN THE INITIAL STAGE. WHEN YOU KNOW THAT SOMETHING WILL BEAR FRUIT, WHICH IS VERY TASTY, BUT SOWING THE SEED TO BEGIN WITH ISN'T THAT ENJOYABLE. WHEN YOU ARE ABIDING IN YOURSELF, AND YOU ARE IN JOY, OR WHEN YOU ARE IN PEACE, IN HAPPINESS, THEN YOU ARE ALREADY IN YOUR SELF

somebody else, the society or authority, imposes on you. 'Anushasana' means the rules that you impose on yourself. Yoga is called a discipline that you impose on yourself.

When does the need for discipline arise? When you are thirsty and you want to drink water, you don't say, 'Oh this is a rule.' You must drink water. When you are hungry, you eat. You don't say, 'I have the discipline of eating when I am hungry.' Or, when you enjoy a scenery, you don't say, 'Oh, I have a discipline of enjoying nature.' When it comes to the question of

enjoyment, no discipline is necessary. When does discipline come into play? Not somewhere where it is enjoyable at the very first step. A child never says, 'I have a discipline of running to my mother when I see her.'

Discipline is needed where something isn't very charming in the initial stage. When you know that something will bear fruit, which is very tasty, but sowing the seed to begin with isn't that enjoyable. When you are abiding in yourself, and you are in joy, or when you are in peace, in happiness, then you are already in your Self. There is no need for discipline there, but when that isn't so, the mind is wagging its tail all the time, then discipline is essential so that you can calm the mind down, it could come back to itself. Something whose fruit will be eventually blissful and joyful.

For example, a diabetes patient says, 'I have a discipline of cutting down on sugar.' Or someone with high cholesterol says, 'I have discipline of not having too much fat in my food,' because food loaded with carbohydrates is very tasty, but it can cause complications later on. After a certain discipline, having fruits that aren't so pleasurable in the beginning offer long-term pleasure. This is known as 'sattvik' pleasure. It is a long-lasting pleasure. That pleasure, which is pleasurable to begin with, but ends in misery, is no pleasure at all. Hence, discipline is necessary to experience sattvik pleasure.

Discipline isn't torturing oneself for nothing. There is no discipline. The purpose of discipline is to attain joy. Do you see the difference? At certain times, people impose discipline on themselves that doesn't offer them any joy in the beginning, nor in the end. That is known as 'tamsik' pleasure. When it isn't so pleasurable to begin with but always leads to joy, it is sattvik pleasure. Rajsik pleasure begins with pleasure but ends up in misery and suffering. Tamsik pleasure appears to be pleasant but it is misery from the beginning to the end.

Follow a certain discipline. You don't have to be extremely rigid about it because you are also beyond discipline. Love takes you beyond the rules. But it is good to have certain rules until we reach there.

Guardians in a War Zone How Volunteers Became Lifelines for Stranded Indian Students in Ukraine

Amid the thunder of war and the shadow of uncertainty, hope wore the face of selfless service. BAPS volunteers emerged as silent heroes, guiding hundreds of anxious Indian students towards safety. From shelter and food to coordinated evacuation, their compassion turned chaos into a path home. This is the story of courage, coordination, and humanity rising above the horrors of conflict



DR GYANANANDAS SWAMI

The conflict between Russia and Ukraine escalated sharply in February 2022 after months of rising tensions. On February 24, Russian President Vladimir Putin announced a “special military operation”, citing security concerns related to NATO expansion. Soon after, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy addressed his nation, calling for resistance.

Within hours, explosions were reported in major Ukrainian cities such as Kyiv and Kharkiv. Missiles struck key infrastructure, air raid sirens wailed continuously, and civilians rushed into underground shelters. Hospitals declared emergencies as casualties began to rise, and the Ukrainian government urged citizens in high-risk areas to evacuate.

Amid the unfolding crisis, thousands of Indian students found themselves stranded, far from home and gripped by uncertainty. With flights suspended and borders under pressure, fear and confusion spread rapidly among them. The situation soon turned into a humanitarian concern, setting the stage for urgent evacuation efforts led by the Government of India. As a result, special flights, diplomatic coordination, and border assistance were set in motion. Yet, given the rapidly deteriorating situation on the ground, it became clear that additional support networks were essential for immediate, on-the-ground relief.

Recognising this urgency, the Prime Minister, Modi, reached out to trusted social and spiritual organisations with a strong global presence. Among them was the BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha, known for its disciplined volunteer base and humanitarian service.

PM Narendra Modi personally called a senior swami of BAPS at midnight on Sunday, February 27, asking for assistance from BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha in ensuring the safe passage of Indian nationals on the Polish, Romanian and Hungarian borders with Ukraine. Thus began a BAPS humanitarian mission. With time



THROUGH ‘OPERATION GANGA’, AROUND 23,000 INDIANS WERE SUCCESSFULLY EVACUATED FROM UKRAINE, OF WHICH 3,700 WERE EVACUATED FROM POLAND IN 17 FLIGHTS

Instructed by His Holiness Mahant Swami Maharaj, volunteers from the UK, Ireland, France, Switzerland, Italy, Germany, Austria, and Poland stepped immediately into the field without concern for their personal jobs, businesses, or plans. They swiftly sprang into action, wholeheartedly supporting the emergency relief efforts on the ground. They set up a mobile field kitchen in the south-eastern Polish city of Rzeszów, which began feeding around 1,000 hot vegetarian meals daily to refugees of all faiths and nationalities. BAPS also arranged accommodation facilities, coordinated medical assistance, and worked closely with the Indian government as well as local partners to further expand the humanitarian efforts as the situation escalated.

Vijay Kumar Singh, former Army Chief of Staff and current Minister of State for Transport and Civil Aviation, observed the tireless efforts of the volunteers first-hand in Rzeszów. He commented, “BAPS has always been at the forefront of community service, being the first to arrive and the last

to leave. The people of India are indebted to your swift, selfless, and organised action.”

In addition to emergency relief and administrative support for local government agencies, BAPS volunteers further provided vital emotional care and comfort to refugees, both at the relief camp set up by the Indian Embassy in Rzeszów as well as on the Polish-Ukrainian border. Closely observing this, Her Excellency Nagma M Mallick, Ambassador of India to Poland & Lithuania, also thanked these volunteers.

Working in close coordination, these combined efforts led to the successful evacuation of stranded Indians. Subsequently, the Government of India, with the support of the Indian Air Force, took full charge of the large-scale airlift operation, aptly dubbed ‘Operation Ganga’. Through ‘Operation Ganga’, around 23,000 Indians were successfully evacuated from Ukraine, of which 3,700 were evacuated from Poland in 17 flights. The flights out of Poland also carried, notably, over 600 students from Sumy who had fled the Ukrainian war zone on a long, perilous journey to Przemyśl in south-eastern Poland.

Mahant Swami Maharaj closely monitored the entire humanitarian effort, offering constant guidance and encouragement. Through repeated video calls, he personally inspired volunteers, strengthening their resolve to serve with dedication and compassion. At the same time, Swamiji offered heartfelt prayers for the safety of the stranded Indian students and for peace and harmony between the two nations.

Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi personally praised and thanked the volunteers of BAPS Swaminarayan Sanstha, who rendered selfless service during the critical evacuation efforts of Indian nationals from Ukraine and neighbouring countries, in a special video conference.

(The writer Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

Commending unsung heroes who shaped wars

ANIL BHAT

One of the very well-known facts of military history is that many acts of high bravery, valour, and self-sacrifice during wars go unmentioned, unrecorded, and unrewarded. The chaos of battle often means that witnesses to heroic acts do not survive, or that administrative systems fail to capture and process commendations in the aftermath.

In large-scale combat, official documentation is often overlooked or impossible to complete. Quite frequently, acts of extraordinary courage are performed by individuals who then die, leaving no one to testify to their actions, or the immediate chain of command is lost. Also often, the bureaucratic process of proposing, reviewing, and approving gallantry awards results in unfairness, where some acts are forgotten or overruled while others are approved. Many soldiers, particularly in support roles, display immense courage that is never formally documented because it is not seen as “above and beyond”

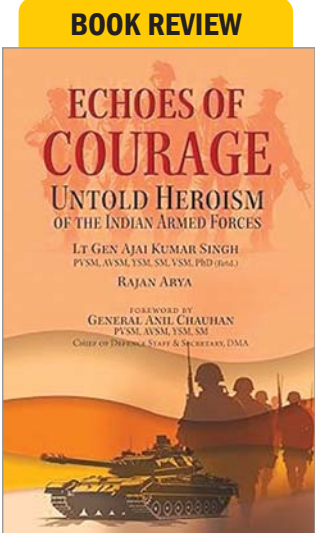
by distant commanders. Often, citations are sent before the full extent of a soldier's actions is known, leading to lesser or no awards for later acts of bravery.

Lieutenant General Ajai Kumar Singh (Retd), former GOC-in-C, Southern Command, and Rajan Arya, who owns Pentagon Press and has published many books on military, strategic, and geopolitical affairs, co-authored this book with poignant and inspiring accounts of eighteen unsung heroes.

The first narrative is about Major Onkar Singh Kalkat, the Brigade Major at Bannu in the North West Frontier Province soon after Partition in 1947, when he came across the top-secret plan issued on August 20, 1947 for Operation Gulmarg, involving the invasion of the Princely State of Jammu and Kashmir in October 1947, very soon after the very bloody Partition planned well in advance by the British. Kalkat was shocked but decided to act normally, and in the dead of the night he and four Sikh soldiers who were posted there dressed as ordinary villagers

and made their way to Delhi to forewarn the Indian Army hierarchy. Following Partition in August 1947, both Indian and Pakistani armies were initially commanded by British officers. Many British officers in Pakistan's high command were supportive of Pakistan, resulting in some intelligence about Indian forces being passed on to Pakistan prior to and during the first India-Pakistan War in 1947-48.

Colonel Narendra 'Bull' Kumar, an outstanding mountaineer, is another legendary figure who, while he was the Commandant of the High Altitude Warfare School in Gulmarg, discovered that Pakistan was sponsoring mountaineering expeditions in the Siachen area. He then led an expedition to the Saltoro Ridge to gather evidence, photographed climbing activity organised by Pakistan, and then his team prepared accurate Indian maps at altitudes between 16,000 to 20,000 feet, where breathing is difficult. During his expedition in 1983, he gathered irrefutable evidence of Pakistan's plan to occupy Siachen by stealth. His efforts led to the



Title: Echoes of courage
Author: Lt Gen Ajai Kumar Singh and Rajan Arya
MRP: ₹495
Publisher: Pentagon Press LLP

Indian Army occupying the Glacier in April 1984.

Another legendary story is that of Baba Harbhajan Singh, a soldier

of 23 Punjab, who died while out on patrol in Sikkim in October 1968. He fell into a rivulet and was swept away. His comrades searched for him for three days but could not find him. On the third night, he appeared in the dream of his colleague, Pritam Singh, and told him the specific spot where his body lay under the snow. Today his mandir (temple) is a three-room structure; his bed is made, shoes polished, and uniform neatly pressed. All personnel posted in that area seek the blessings of this guardian.

Zafar-4 is the tale of an Indian spy in Pakistan during the 1971 war. He put his life at stake, shunned the limelight, but carried on the dangerous work of spying silently, with the threat of torture and death constantly on his mind. He believed in doing what he did without flinching, even though it is the kind of duty that never gets acknowledged, let alone rewarded.

Major Ashok Tara of 14 GUARDS was instrumental in saving the lives of the family of Sheikh Mujibur Rehman when they were

under house arrest in December 1971. The 'right man for an impossible task'. When we speak of the 1971 War, we should also remember the scene in the house in Dhanmondi: a frightened family, a group of defeated soldiers, and an Indian Major saying it's over, come out, you are safe.

There are many more stories, including that of Captain Anuj Nayyar, who was awarded the Maha Vir Chakra in the Kargil War. Brigadier Navin Kumar Maini rose to the occasion on the night of December 2, 1971 and saved many lives during the Bhopal Gas Tragedy. Badlu Ram, whose name has been immortalised by the Assam Regiment. The ghost of Lansdowne is another remarkably anecdote that revolves around the Garhwal Rifles Regimental Centre.

While fifteen of these accounts are of military personnel, including one lady army officer, three are of animals — a mule named Pedogin, a dog named Mansi, and a Himalayan mountain bear named Bahadur. Mules are used by the army's animal transport units

in high-altitude areas for carrying food supplies, rations, weapons, ammunition, and construction material. Dogs of the dog units are very good at detecting explosives, narcotics, and mines, tracking militants, guarding installations, and conducting search and rescue operations, particularly in difficult terrain like avalanche-prone zones. They are also used as “silent warriors” for surveillance, infantry patrolling, and direct assault in high-risk missions. Bahadur is the story of a bear who bonded very well with the soldiers and became a source of joy for them.

As the Chief of Defence Staff, General Anil Chauhan, wrote in his foreword, “courage is often spoken about in moments of triumph, yet its truest expression is revealed in silence — when duty demands action without promise of recognition, when fear must be mastered without witness, and when duty continues despite personal cost”. The book is most inspiring and informative.

(The book reviewer is a VSM (Retd), a strategic affairs analyst and former spokesperson, Defence Ministry and Indian Army)